THE HOLLOW HEIR

The Guidebook

The story, scene by scene: the Prologue to Day 4

What to say, how to play every character, and what happens when your players poke at absolutely everything.

Written by Zibby

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to use this Guidebook

The DM Guide tells you how the game works. This book tells you how to tell the story.

You already have the **DM Guide**: the rules, every button on the GM screen, the puzzles and the finale. This Guidebook sits beside it and does a different job. It walks you through the first half of the week, from the owl at the window to the end of Day 4, one scene at a time. For every scene it tells you where everyone is, what to read out, what each person says and how they say it, and what happens when your players do something nobody planned for.

Your players test everything. They will open every barrel, lift every rug, tap every wall and try Alohomora on the Headmaster's hat. This book is written for exactly that table. Part 1 gives you a system for answering any poke in a second. Part 5 goes room by room through every location picture, object by object.

The boxes in this book

READ ALOUD

Parchment boxes are read aloud, as written or in your own words.

IN CHARACTER: SOMEONE IN THE CASTLE

"Purple boxes are a character speaking. Read them in their voice. Each character's voice is described in Part 2."

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

Red boxes mean stop and let the players talk.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Teal boxes say what to press in the app.

TIP

Gold boxes are advice you can take or leave.

If they…	
	Tables like this one list what the players might do in a scene, and what happens when they do.

How the book is laid out

Part	What it is for	When to read it
1. The poking table	A system for answering any “I look under the…” in one breath.	Before the first session. Keep the quick-reference page handy.
2. The cast	How to play every person in the castle: voice, body, secrets, reactions.	Before the first session, then dip in.
3. The Prologue	Letters to the Sorting, scene by scene.	At the table, in order.
4. Days 1 to 4	Every block of every day: who is where, what appears, what to say.	At the table, in order.
5. The castle, room by room	Every object in every picture, and what poking it does.	Whenever someone says “I search the…”.
6. The mystery so far	Every clue up to Day 4, where it is, and how to handle accusations.	Between sessions.
7. The Quest Guide	Getting players to bite, and every quest in depth. Also printed on its own.	Before the first session.

TIP

You do not need to memorise any of this. Read Parts 1 and 2 once. Then read each scene a minute before it happens, while the players are busy with their phones.

PART 1

The poking table

Your players will touch everything. Here is how to make every touch worth it.

The golden rule

When a player pokes at something, they are telling you what they find interesting. Reward that. Every poke gets **something**: a sight, a smell, a sound, a small find, or a consequence. The only wrong answer is a flat "there's nothing there". Even an empty barrel smells of old apples and has a name scratched inside the lid.

But not every poke gets *loot*. If every barrel holds a Galleon, the barrels stop being interesting by Day 2. The trick is to make most pokes give **flavour**, some give **a small find**, and a few give **something that matters**.

The three answers

Answer	How often	What it sounds like
Flavour	Most of the time	A detail that makes the place feel real, or a joke. "Inside the barrel: pickled onions, and one of them is looking at you."
A small find	About one poke in four, and at most once per place per day	A coin, a sweet, a note, a useful hint. Roll on the Pocket Finds table below, or pick.
Something that matters	Only where this book says so	A clue, a quest item, a secret passage, a chest. These are placed by the app or by you, and Part 5 says where.

TIP

A good habit: when a player pokes something for the first time in a place, give them a little more than flavour. When they poke the same kind of thing for the fifth time, give them a joke. The joke is the reward for persistence.

The poke ladder

Every investigation climbs the same three rungs. Decide which rung they are on, and you know what to do.

Rung	What the player says	What you do
1. Look	"What's in the corner?" "Is there anything on the desk?"	No roll. Describe what anyone would see. Mention one thing that invites a closer look.
2. Search	"I open the barrel." "I look behind the painting." "I tap the walls."	Roll if there is something to find or a reason it could go wrong. Usually INT (searching), WIS (noticing) or DEX (doing it quietly).
3. Force	"I smash the crate." "I cast Alohomora." "I climb the shelves."	Roll, and there is always a risk: noise, damage, a teacher, lost house points. Say the risk before they roll.

Picking the number

How hard	DC	Example
Easy	8	Finding the pear on the fruit painting once they know to look
Normal	12	Searching a cluttered desk, noticing a portrait pretending to sleep
Hard	15	Finding a hidden catch on a bookcase, sneaking past Filch
Very hard	18	Picking an old castle lock with a hairpin, lying to the Headmaster

Players roll on the Dice tab of their phones and tell you the total. A natural 20 always gives something extra. A natural 1 always gives something funny, never something cruel.

> **TIP**
>
> Before a Force roll, always say the risk out loud: "You can smash it, but it will be loud. Filch is two corridors away." Then let them choose. The best moments come from players deciding the risk is worth it.

Common things, and what is in them

Use this table for anything not listed in Part 5. Roll a d6 or pick the one that fits the room.

Thing	1–2: flavour	3–4: a little more	5–6: a small find
Barrel	Rainwater and a drowned leaf	Pickled onions. One blinks.	A cork with a Galleon pushed into it (+1 Galleon)
Crate or box	Straw and the smell of apples	Old school robes, moth-eaten, with a name tag too faded to read	Pumpkin Pasty, wrapped in paper
Cupboard or wardrobe	Coats that smell of rain	A broom that tries to sweep them out	A spare Pepperup Potion behind the brooms
Under a bed or table	Dust bunnies that scatter like mice	A sock, a quill, a note: "meet me at the lake"	A Chocolate Frog (the card is a common one)
Behind a painting	Bare stone and a draught	The painting's back is signed and dated a hundred years ago	A gap in the stone: a hidden passage (see Hidden passages)
Tapping the walls	Solid stone, cold under the knuckles	A hollow sound. A loose stone with a sweet wrapper behind it	A hollow sound and a draught: a hidden passage
A rug	Floorboards and a lost button	A scorch mark shaped like a hand	A trapdoor that is nailed shut (fun to argue about)
Fireplace	Warm ash	Soot falls on whoever leaned in. They sneeze.	A note half burnt: a scrap of someone's homework, or a clue line from Part 6
Bookshelf	Books, alphabetised by smell	A book bites, or sings, or sighs when opened	A bookmark that is a Chocolate Frog card
Suit of armour	It creaks when you look at it	The visor snaps shut on fingers (1 HP)	"You find Galleons in an old suit of armour." +5 Galleons
Statue	Cold stone, a smooth worn nose	It turns its head to watch them leave	A loose plinth with a hidden button: a passage
Window	The grounds, the lake, the forest	An owl taps to be let in. It has nothing for them. It wants a treat.	Something moving at the edge of the forest at night
Plants and pots	Earth and worms	The plant bites (1 HP), or sneezes pollen	A seed pod worth giving to Longbottom (+5 house points when they do)

Thing	1–2: flavour	3–4: a little more	5–6: a small find
Cauldron	Something brown and bubbling	It smells of whatever they love most	Leftover potion: a Pepperup, if they dare
Trunk	Robes and books	A lock with no keyhole	Could be a chest on the map. If not: a Remembrall, glowing red

ON THE GM SCREEN

To hand over a find: Players tab, Give item (or the +Galleons button). Chests already on the map are opened by the players from the Here tab on their phones, with their own roll.

Pocket finds

When a poke earns a small find and you want something quick, roll a d20.

d20	Find	d20	Find
1	A note that just says “behind you”. Nobody is.	11	Bertie Bott’s Beans (give the item; eating it spins the bean wheel)
2	A Knut, a Sickle and a button (no game value, great to hold)	12	A Chocolate Frog
3	A love letter to a professor, unsigned	13	A Pumpkin Pasty
4	A Dungbomb (it goes off if dropped: everyone nearby rolls CON or gags)	14	+3 Galleons in a lost purse
5	Filch’s list of banned items, very long	15	A Pepperup Potion
6	A self-inking quill that writes rude words	16	A scrap with three runes and their letters pencilled under them (confirm those letters in the rune notebook)
7	A Gobstone that complains	17	Extendable Ears
8	A cat hair. Mrs Norris was here.	18	A Focus Draught
9	A tiny portrait of a mouse, very chatty	19	A Remembrall
10	A torn page of someone’s Potions homework (marked: Troll)	20	Felix Felicis, or a real clue from Part 6

TIP

Rolls 16 and 20 are your levers. If the players are stuck on runes, use 16. If they are stuck on the mystery, use 20 to hand them a clue they missed.

Hidden passages

Hogwarts is full of them, and finding one is the best feeling in the game. When a search finds a passage, decide where it goes. Good options:

- **A shortcut** to a place on the same floor. Next time they go there, they save a scene (tell them, and let them skip a corridor).
- **A way past Filch.** At Curfew, a known passage lets them skip one spin of Out after curfew.
- **A spy hole** into a room. Behind the portraits of the Grand Staircase, a passage has holes where a painted figure's eyes should be. From there they can watch the Defence classroom, or the Great Hall, without being seen.
- **A dead end** with something in it: a skeleton of a broom, an old wrapper, initials carved by students fifty years ago.

One rule: no passage leads into the Undercroft before Day 7, and none goes into the Restricted Section without the players paying for it somehow (a roll, a risk, a cost).

> **ON THE GM SCREEN**
>
> The Out after curfew wheel and Hogwarts surprises wheel both have a Secret / Passage result. When it lands, the passage is real: describe it and let them name it. Players love naming passages.

Spells on the world

Once they have a wand, they will point it at everything. Say yes as often as you can. These are the spells they have by Day 4, and some they might know from home.

Spell	On the world	Where it matters
Lumos	Light. Dark corners give up their secrets: footprints in dust, writing on a wall, eyes in the dark.	The Restricted Section at night, the Dungeons, the Forest. Devil's Snare hates it.
Alohomora	Opens ordinary locks: cupboards, classroom doors, desk drawers. (Taught on Day 5, so only those who knew it before.)	Very old locks ignore it: the Restricted Section gate, the serpent door, the Turning Lock.
Wingardium Leviosa	Lifts things that are out of reach: a book from a high shelf, a key from a ledge.	The Trophy Room's top shelf, the Library gallery.
Accio	Summons a small visible object. Not people, not things in someone's pocket, not things they can't name.	Fetching the stolen jars from Peeves's hiding place, if they have seen them.
Reparo	Mends broken things. Lovely for apologising to Filch.	A smashed vase is +5 house points restored and one less enemy.
Aguamenti	Water. Puts out fires, fills cauldrons, soaks Peeves.	The Greenhouses. Longbottom is grateful.
Expelliarmus	Knocks a wand away. On a student, it starts a fight.	On a teacher: −10 points and detention, unless they had a very good reason.
Incendio	Fire. Burns paper, cloth and wood; stone just gets warm. Taught on Day 7.	Paint burns. If they try it on a portrait before Day 7, the portrait screams and every portrait in the corridor goes quiet.
Flipendo	A push. Knocks over barrels, opens heavy doors, startles owls.	Fun at the Owlery. Expect feathers.
Finite Incantatem	Ends a spell. On an enchanted object it goes still.	On a portrait: the figure freezes for a minute, mid-sentence, like a paused film.
Stupefy	Knocks someone out. The Sinclair starts with it.	Never quietly. Anyone who sees it tells a teacher.

The covered painting and spells

Sooner or later someone will try to curse, burn, cut or summon the covered painting. Be ready:

Diffindo or a knife on the cloth	The cord parts. The cloth slips a hand's width and stops, as if something caught it from the inside. Through the gap: a corner of gilded frame and the smell of turpentine.
Incendio or any fire	The flame slides off the cloth like water off oil. The cloth is not even warm. Somewhere under it, someone laughs very softly.
Accio	The painting does not move. The caster's wand hand goes cold to the elbow for an hour. (No mechanical effect; describe it.)
Pulling the cloth right off	They can't. It is as heavy as a lead curtain. With a STR 16 check, it lifts for one second: they see a painted young man, beautiful and unfinished, the background still bare canvas. His eyes open. Give that student the Fear status for the rest of the scene.
Talking to it	Before Day 5 it says almost nothing. One line, velvet-soft: "Not yet, child. Not yet."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Statuses are on the Table tab: tap a student, then choose from the status list (Fear, Stunned, Silenced and so on).

Breaking the rules

They will. Hogwarts has a simple system for it, and it is also your best steering tool.

They…	What happens
Are out after curfew	Spin Out after curfew for each group that moves (Wheels & dice tab). Filch means detention.
Get detention	Detention is in the Trophy Room with Filch, polishing cups. It starts the secret quest The Old Cup. Detention is a reward in disguise.
Fight in a corridor	−5 points each, unless a teacher is in the room, then −10 and detention.
Curse a teacher	−20 points and detention. If it is Ashgrove, he forgives them warmly and it is somehow worse.
Steal from a classroom	If anyone sees: −10 points. If nobody sees: Portrait gossip wheel for the nearest portrait.
Go into the Forest	Out of bounds always. −10 points if caught. Spin the Forbidden Forest wheel each visit.
Lie to a teacher	CHA check against the teacher's WIS: Filch 10, Grimsby 14, Vance 15, the Headmaster 18. Ashgrove believes everything, which should worry them.

TIP

Points work best as theatre. Say the number like a teacher would, then hit the Points button while everyone watches the hourglass on the TV. A table that has just lost twenty points will behave for exactly one block.

When they go somewhere early

Players with a map will try to go everywhere on Day 1. Let them. The castle is ready for it.

The Forbidden Forest, Day 1	It is dark under the trees even at noon. Spin the Forest wheel. The centaur is there from Day 1 afternoon. Bramble is not findable until Scamander's lesson on Day 3, but they can hear something large and frightened deep in the trees.
The Restricted Section	It is secret on the map until they find the way in: a gate at the back of the Library, chained, with a lock that ignores Alohomora. A Hard (15) DEX roll with a hairpin, a very good lie to the librarian, or the Okafor's Curse-Breaker gift gets them through. Inside before Day 3: chained books that whisper, nothing they need yet.
The Room of Requirement	Walking past the blank wall three times, thinking of what they need, works any day. Before Day 5 the room is full of junk and one ancient chest (it is on the map from Day 1). The ticking chest of the Turning Lock is there too, but the three ring clues are scattered.
The Undercroft	There is no way down until they find it: the stair is hidden behind the Dungeons fireplace. If they find it early (Hard WIS search of the fireplace, or the Marlowe asking a snake), the stair ends at the serpent door. The Marlowe's key and Parseltongue open it, onto a long cold corridor where the covered painting hangs. The great inner chamber stays sealed until the seventh night: "The far door hums. It is not ready for you. Not yet."
Hogsmeade	Not until Day 6. The gates are locked and Filch is very pleased about it.
A teacher's office	Locked. Inside Grimsby's: ingredients, a half-brewed cauldron (Day 5 clue), very bad poetry. Inside Ashgrove's: more paintings than the classroom, all facing the wall. Turning one round is a WIS 12 check not to scream.

PART 2

The cast

How to play everyone in the castle, from the Headmaster to a talking mouse.

Every person in The Hollow Heir has a voice, a want and a secret. Get those three right and you can improvise the rest. Each card below gives you the voice in one sentence you can act, where they are during the week, what they want from the players, what they are hiding, and how they react to the things your players will definitely try: questions, accusations, curses, bribes and flattery.

Three tricks for playing a crowd

- **One physical habit each.** Flitwick bounces on his toes. Grimsby never looks up. Ashgrove touches his cuff when he lies. Pick the habit, do it every time, and the table will know who is talking before you say a word.
- **Every character answers a different question to the one asked.** Nobody in a mystery gives a straight answer. They answer what they care about. The Headmaster answers with a worry. Peeves answers with a rhyme. The painting answers with a question.
- **Let them be wrong.** Characters believe things that are not true. Filch thinks students are the problem. Longbottom thinks Ashgrove is lovely. That is not you lying to the players: it is the world being full of people.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Every person's talking points for the current day are on the GM screen: tap them on the map or in The castle this block panel. The Conversation Book lists them all. This chapter is about how to perform them.

The Headmaster

Very old, very kind, and more frightened than he lets the students see.

Usually found	The Great Hall at Lunch. His office the rest of the time (not on the map: if the players ask for him, he comes to them).
How to play them	Speak slowly. Leave long pauses. Look at the ceiling before answering, as if the answer is written there. Never answer a question directly the first time: answer the worry behind it.
What they want	To keep the school open and every student alive. He would rather lie to them than frighten them.
What they hide	He has heard the name Corvin Vale before. His predecessor's predecessor invited Vale to paint the staff, and "it did not end well". He has not connected it to this year yet, and does not want to.

They ask him a straight question	He answers a different one. "What happened to her?" becomes "She is alive. Hold on to that."
They accuse a teacher	"I have known every one of my staff for longer than you have been alive. Which is not, I grant you, proof of anything." He writes something down.
They accuse him	He laughs, genuinely. "If only I had the energy." Then he looks at them properly and says: "Be careful who you say that to. Not everyone in this castle laughs."
They curse or threaten him	It simply does not work. Their wand spits sparks. He sighs. −20 points and he does not look angry, only tired, which is far worse.
They flatter him	He enjoys it enormously and gives them a sherbet lemon. It changes nothing.

IN CHARACTER: THE HEADMASTER, WELCOME FEAST

"Every year I tell first-years the same thing: Hogwarts will look after you, if you let it. This year I find myself hoping that is true."

IN CHARACTER: THE HEADMASTER, DAY 2 ONWARDS

"They are alive. That is what matters tonight. Whatever took their colour, it did not take their lives… yet."

IN CHARACTER: THE HEADMASTER, DAY 3 ONWARDS

"Magic that drains and does not kill is old magic. Older than this castle's current portraits. Perhaps ask them."

IN CHARACTER: THE HEADMASTER, DAY 4, IF ASKED ABOUT VALE

A long pause. "A name I have not heard since I was a boy. A painter. My predecessor's predecessor invited him to paint the staff. It did not end well."

Professor Ashgrove

Defence Against the Dark Arts. Everyone's favourite. The hands of the villain, though he does not fully know it.

Usually found	The Defence classroom almost all day. The Great Hall at Lunch, except Day 2 (showing off his portraits in his classroom).
How to play them	Warm, bright, remembers every name on the first day. Leans in when he listens. Touches his left cuff when he is about to lie: do it every time. From Day 4, he sometimes stops mid-sentence and tilts his head, as if someone behind him said something.
What they want	To be loved. Underneath that, to be free of the voice in his head. He found the painting, and it has been speaking to him ever since.
What they hide	He brought the painting to Hogwarts. Vale is in his head, using his hands at night. By day he half-remembers, and is terrified of what he remembers. His new portraits are Vale's eyes around the castle.

They ask about his paintings	He lights up and tells a story about each one. One of the portraits behind him does not laugh at his jokes.
They ask about Vale (Day 4+)	His smile stays exactly where it is. His eyes go still. He touches his cuff. "Never heard of him. Off you go, now." A WIS 12 check notices the lie.
They accuse him (before Day 6)	Hurt, not angry. "I understand. You are frightened. So am I." He gives them +5 house points for courage. It is the most unsettling thing he does all week.
They search his desk	DEX 13 to do it unseen. Inside: marking, a paint-stained rag (wet), and a sketch of the Undercroft corridor that he does not remember drawing.
They curse him	He deflects it easily and smiles. "Excellent form! Wrong target." −10 points, and he looks at them a beat too long.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR ASHGROVE, FIRST LESSON

"Defence is not about fighting. It is about making sure the fight never reaches you. Now. Wands up."

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR ASHGROVE, ABOUT HIS PAINTINGS

"I collect them! Every one has a story. Some of them are even true."

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR ASHGROVE, DAY 4, ALONE, A SLIP

He is looking at a painting of a ship in a storm. Without turning round: "Do you ever feel that something is watching you through your own eyes?" Then, brightly: "Ignore me. Long week."

Professor Grimsby

Potions. Nobody's favourite. The red herring, and secretly the one trying hardest to help.

Usually found	The Dungeons, all day, every day. Never at the Great Hall except at Lunch, and then only to glare.
How to play them	Never look up from what you are doing. Clipped, sarcastic sentences. "Hm." He says "Hm" the way other people say whole paragraphs. When genuinely worried, his hands shake and he hides them in his sleeves.
What they want	To wake the drained students without anyone knowing he cares.
What they hide	He is brewing a Restorative Draught in secret. The raid on his store cupboard frightens him more than he admits, because he thinks someone is trying to stop the draught. (It was Peeves.)

They ask what was stolen	"Boomslang skin. Lacewing flies. Gone. If it was a first-year, they will be scrubbing cauldrons until they are forty." He gives them Stolen Ingredients.
They accuse him (any day)	"Get out of my dungeon." Then, as they leave, quietly: "If you were right, you would be grey by now."
They bring back the stolen jars	He takes them without a word. Then, still not looking up: "Five points. Each. Don't tell anyone." (Give 5 points each, on top of the quest reward.)
They look at his cauldron	He slams the lid. "Not for you." A WIS 14 check sees it is the colour of dawn, which is what a Restorative Draught looks like half-made.
They are kind to him	It confuses him. He becomes, very briefly, almost nice: a hint about potions, or a spare Pepperup.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR GRIMSBY, FIRST LESSON

"Sit. Open your books. If anyone's cauldron explodes, they clean it up themselves."

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR GRIMSBY, DAY 3

"Hm. If I knew what was draining them, do you think I would be standing here talking to you?" He turns back to his cauldron. His hands are shaking.

Professor Flitwick

Charms. Tiny, delighted, and the best duellist in the castle.

Usually found	The Charms classroom. The Great Hall at Lunch, and every Free time from Day 2 for the Dueling Club.
How to play them	Squeaky, fast, stands on a pile of books. Bounces on his toes when pleased. Claps at clever answers, even wrong ones. Falls off the books once a week.
What they want	A first-year Dueling Club champion, ideally a Ravenclaw.
What they hide	Nothing about the attacks. He is frightened of the silent portraits because he has seen it happen twice before in fifty years, and both times someone died.

They ask for help with a spell	Delighted. He coaches them for a moment: advantage on their next attempt at that spell.
They ask about the portraits (Day 3+)	“Portraits go quiet when they are frightened. In fifty years I have only seen it twice. I did not like it either time.”
They challenge him to a duel	He accepts with joy, disarms them in one flick before they finish the word, and hands their wand back. +5 points “for nerve”.
They accuse him	He laughs so hard he falls off his books.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR FLITWICK, FIRST LESSON

“Swish and flick! It is all in the wrist, and a little in the heart. Try again, try again!”

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR FLITWICK, DUELING CLUB

“Every evening in the Great Hall! Fair fights, friendly spells. I am looking for a first-year champion, you know.”

Professor Longbottom

Herbology. Gentle, a bit nervous, braver than he looks.

Usually found	The Greenhouses. The Hospital Wing from Day 3, brewing and watching the drained students.
How to play them	Laughs nervously. Talks to plants mid-sentence and apologises to them. Stops being nervous the moment someone is in danger.
What they want	To save the drained students. He believes in the Restorative Draught.
What they hide	He took down a painting Ashgrove gave him because it kept changing. He has told nobody, because it sounds mad.

They ask about the victims (Day 3+)	“All of them were near a painting. The night before, every one of them said they’d been dreaming about paint.”
They offer to help brew	He nearly hugs them. Wake the Sleepers. Every Mandrake leaf they bring is worth a smile and a story.
They are rough with his plants	The plant bites them first (1 HP). Then he looks disappointed, which is worse.
They ask about Ashgrove	“Lovely man. Brought me a painting of the greenhouses for my office.” Day 6 onwards he adds the part about it changing.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR LONGBOTTOM, FIRST LESSON

"Earmuffs on, everyone! These are Mandrakes. Their cry won't kill you at this age, but it'll ruin your afternoon. Gently does it."

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR LONGBOTTOM, DAY 3, QUIETLY

"There's a draught. Old magic. It might bring them back. I'd need three Mandrake leaves, and someone with a steady hand at a cauldron."

Professor Vance

Transfiguration. Deputy Headmistress. Precise, stern, fair.

Usually found	The Transfiguration classroom. The Great Hall at Lunch.
How to play them	Tap your finger on the table once before every sentence. Never raise your voice. Use their full name.
What they want	Precision. Order. Silence.
What they hide	She suspects Ashgrove, purely because he is too popular and too new. She has no evidence and refuses to say so without it.

They ask if paint can become real (Day 3+)	"With enough power and enough time, anything can be made to become anything. That is precisely why we do not allow it."
They tell her a theory	She listens to the end without interrupting, then asks the one question that breaks it. If the theory survives her question, +10 points.
They break a rule in front of her	She does not shout. She takes 10 points and writes their name in a small black book.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR VANCE, FIRST LESSON

"Transfiguration is the most complex magic you will learn. It is also the most dangerous. Pay attention."

Professor Scamander

Care of Magical Creatures. Dreamy, and much sharper than she seems.

Usually found	The old gamekeeper's hut. The Forest edge on Day 3 Free time.
How to play them	Speak softly and look slightly past people. The suitcase at your feet thumps; ignore it, or apologise to it. Kinder to creatures than to students.
What they want	Creatures treated kindly. Bramble home.
What they hide	The creatures of the forest are restless because something under the castle is calling. She noticed on Day 1.

They ask about the suitcase	"Oh, don't mind that. He's shy." The suitcase growls.
They are cruel to an animal	She goes very still and very cold. −10 points and she will not speak to them until they make it right.
They ask about the forest (Day 3+)	"The creatures are restless. Something under the castle is calling, and they don't like the sound of it."

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR SCAMANDER, DAY 3, TO THE THORNBURY

"A grey hippogriff at the edge of the forest. Proud. Torn tag on her leg. I believe she might be yours."

Madam Hooch

Flying instructor. Barks. Hates excuses.

Usually found	The Quidditch Pitch all day. The Great Hall at Lunch.
How to play them	A sports coach on match day. Short sentences, a whistle, hands on hips. Respects anyone who gets back on a broom.
What they want	Nobody falling off a broom.
What they hide	Nothing. She is the only person in the castle with nothing to hide, and she would like everyone else to get on with it.

They want to borrow a broom outside lessons	"Absolutely not." A CHA 14 check, or real enthusiasm about Quidditch: "Five minutes. Below the stands. If you break it, you buy it."
They fall off	"Up. Again." She does not help them up. +5 points if they get straight back on.

IN CHARACTER: MADAM HOOCH, DAY 4

"Right hand over the broom and say UP! Not up, not please, UP! And if anyone flies into the hoops, I am not picking you up."

Filch and Mrs Norris

The caretaker, and his cat, who is somehow everywhere.

Usually found	The Entrance Hall in the morning, the Trophy Room in the afternoon (detentions), the Grand Staircase at Curfew.
How to play them	Mutter. Shuffle. Talk to the cat instead of the students: "Did you hear that, my sweet? Out of bounds, they are." Rattle a ring of keys when you threaten.
What they want	To catch someone, anyone, after curfew.
What they hide	He has keys to every corridor where students were drained, which makes him look guilty. He was supervising a detention on night two, which clears him.

They are out after curfew near him	Spin Out after curfew. If he catches them: −10 points and detention in the Trophy Room.
They ask where he was on night two (Day 3+)	"Supervising detention, weren't I? Two Gryffindors, three hours, every cup in that room. Ask them." That clears him.
They are nice to Mrs Norris	She purrs. Filch is so shocked he forgets to take points. Once.
They prank him	Spin Portrait gossip for who saw it. If anyone did, −10 and detention. If not, he blames Peeves and is happy all day.

IN CHARACTER: FILCH, ANY DAY

"Out of bounds, out of bounds, all of it. I've got keys to every door in this castle, and I know who opens them."

IN CHARACTER: FILCH, DAY 4

"New paintings every week. I don't hang them. Nobody asked me. Nobody asks me anything."

Peeves

A poltergeist. Chaos in a bow tie.

Usually found	Moves all day: the Grand Staircase, the Library, the Dungeons, the Courtyard. Everywhere Filch is not.
How to play them	Shriek. Rhyme. Never stand still: you can literally move your chair. Throw things (a crumpled napkin at the table works).
What they want	Chaos. He stole Grimsby's ingredients to throw at students.
What they hide	He has seen the painted man walking at night, and he is the only one who is not frightened of him, because he thinks it is funny.

They corner him about the jars	DEX or CHA 13: "Wasn't me! Was me. Lacewing flies make lovely missiles!" The jars are on the Grand Staircase.
They try to curse him	It goes through him. He blows a raspberry and drops a bucket of something on the caster. 1 HP and their dignity.
They ask what he has seen (Day 4+)	"Painted man walking, painted man stalking, out of the frame and down to the deep!"
They make him laugh	He tells them one true thing, by accident, then vanishes.

IN CHARACTER: PEEVES, ANY DAY

"Ickle firsties, lost and scared, wandering where the painting stared!" He blows a raspberry and vanishes through the ceiling.

The ghost

A sad, polite ghost who died three hundred years ago. Name her yourself; the players will ask.

Usually found	The Entrance Hall in the morning, the Grand Staircase in the afternoon, the Library or the Restricted Section at night.
How to play them	Very old-fashioned, very polite, drifts through walls in the middle of sentences. Sighs before speaking.
What they want	Someone to listen to her.
What they hide	Vale painted her when she was alive. She died the next winter. She saw a man step out of a frame on the night of the second attack.

They ask for directions	"The staircases change on Fridays, and on Tuesdays if they are cross. Ask the portraits. Most of them are kind."

They ask what she saw (Day 3+)	“On the night of the second attack, I saw a man step out of a frame. Out. As if it were a door. He was beautiful, in a way I did not like.”
They ask about Vale (Day 4+)	“I knew him. He painted me, once. He said I would last forever on canvas. I died the next winter. I have never seen the painting since.”
They walk through her	She shivers, and so do they. Cold to the bone for a moment. She is offended for exactly one sentence.

Pip the house-elf

A kitchen elf who would very much like to feed you.

Usually found	The Kitchens, always.
How to play them	Bow constantly. Speak about yourself as Pip. Get so excited about food that you trip over the words.
What they want	To feed the students. To be thanked.
What they hide	The portraits whisper at night about a door that wants opening. Pip has heard them and does not like it.

They ask for food	“Pip is bringing pies! Pip is bringing pasties!” Give a Pumpkin Pasty or a Chocolate Frog.
They thank Pip properly	Pip cries with happiness and tells them one rumour (Day 3+: the portraits and the door; Day 5+: the Undercroft).
They are rude to Pip	Pip apologises to them for being rude to Pip. It is awful. Anyone with a heart rolls WIS or feels terrible.

The centaur

Proud, cryptic, speaks only of stars.

Usually found	The Forbidden Forest from Day 1 afternoon.
How to play them	Speak to the sky, not to them. Long pauses. Never a straight answer, always a true one.
What they want	For humans to leave the forest alone.
What they hide	He knows something old is waking. He will not interfere in human affairs, except to warn.

They demand answers	He turns his back and walks away. They will not find him again that day.
They ask about the hippogriff (Day 3+)	“She is deeper in. Afraid. Go gently, or do not go at all.”
They threaten him	Very bad idea. He draws his bow and looks at them. Everyone rolls WIS: failure means Fear for the scene. Then he is gone.

IN CHARACTER: THE CENTAUR, ANY DAY

“Mars is bright tonight. Something old is waking beneath the stone.”

The librarian

Whispers. Furious about noise. Knows every book by its smell.

Usually found	The Library, always.
How to play them	Whisper everything, even when angry. Especially when angry. Point instead of explaining.
What they want	Silence. And her books back on time.
What they hide	She keeps the key to the Restricted Section on a ribbon round her neck. She has noticed someone has been in there at night.

They are loud	"SHHH." They lose 5 points and the next search roll in the Library is at disadvantage.
They ask for books about paintings	"Portraiture, aisle nine. Enchanted portraiture, the Restricted Section. Which you are not permitted to enter."
They ask to enter the Restricted Section	Only with a teacher's signed note. Forging one is a DEX 15. Vance would sign for a good reason; Ashgrove signs anything, cheerfully.

Professor Greaves

Divination. Tall, thin, very still. Reads the cards for a price. A showman who half believes his own act.

Usually found	The Library, in a velvet-curtained alcove at the back of the stacks, behind a single candle.
How to play them	Speak slowly and low. Never blink first. Call every student "child". Touch the cards as if they might bite. When the news is bad, go quiet rather than sorry.
What they want	Twenty Galleons, and an audience. He loves the moment just before the last card turns.
What they hide	He has seen all three cards reversed only a handful of times in thirty years, and he remembers every name. He does not like the covered painting, and will not say why.

They ask for a reading	"Twenty Galleons. On the table. And one of you per house, per day; the cards tire of a crowd." Then run it (Part 4, Day 1 Free time, **Professor Greaves and his cards**).
They want their money back	"You paid to look, not to like what you saw."
They ask about Vale or the painting	He covers the deck with his hand. "Some faces should stay under their cloth." Nothing more, unless a reading turns up the Moon or the High Priestess.
They try to peek at or stack the deck	He catches their wrist without looking up. "The cards know." The reading is refused for that house today.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR GREAVES

"Sit. No, not there. There, where the candle can see you. Now cut the deck. Left hand. Your left."

The matron

Brisk, warm, exhausted. Runs the Hospital Wing.

Usually found	The Hospital Wing, always.
How to play them	Tuck in blankets while you talk. Never stop moving. Call everyone “dear”.
What they want	Her patients awake.
What they hide	Cassius Thorne was in her ward on night three with a Bludger bruise. That clears him.

They ask about the drained students	“Alive. Cold. They don’t wake, and they don’t dream. I’ve never seen anything like it.”
They ask about Cassius (Day 4+)	“Thorne? He was here on the third night with a Bludger bruise. All night. Snored like a troll.”
They are hurt	She heals them to full and tuts. Any student can be healed here once per block.

Prefect Sinclair

A Ravenclaw prefect. The Sinclair’s older sister. Brave, tired, and the first victim.

Usually found	The Express. The Great Hall at Lunch, the Grand Staircase in the evening (Days 1–2). Drained outside Ravenclaw Tower on Day 2 at Curfew, then in the Hospital Wing.
How to play them	Brisk and protective. Laughs things off when scared. Ruffles her younger sibling’s hair in front of everyone.
What they want	For someone to believe her that the castle is wrong.
What they hide	She has been dreaming about paintings since the summer. She has felt the cold in the corridor under the castle.

They meet her after dinner (Keep an Eye Out)	She shows them a corridor where every portrait is empty, and a dead end near the Dungeons where the air is cold. “That’s where it’s worst. Under there, somewhere.”
The Sinclair talks to her alone	She drops the act. “I’m scared. Don’t tell Mum.” Give the Sinclair the clue of the cold corridor.
After she is drained (Day 3+)	She lies grey and still. If someone holds her hand, she whispers one word: “Canvas.”

IN CHARACTER: PREFECT SINCLAIR, ON THE TRAIN

“First years? Compartments at the back. And if anyone gives you trouble, find me.” To the Sinclair, quietly: “I’ve been having bad dreams. About paintings.”

IN CHARACTER: PREFECT SINCLAIR, DAY 1

“I’m probably being silly. But meet me by the Grand Staircase after dinner. I want to show you something.”

Cassius Thorne

A smug older Slytherin. A rival, not a villain.

Usually found	The Courtyard in Free time, the Great Hall at Lunch, the Hospital Wing on night three.
How to play them	A lazy drawl. Flip a Galleon. Call everyone by their surname, loudly. Never sit up straight.
What they want	To win. Anything.
What they hide	He holds the other half of the Marauder's Map. He is frightened of the attacks and covers it with sneering.

They insult him back	He enjoys it. Respect, a little. Now he wants to duel them.
They challenge him to a duel	In the Dueling Club, gladly (use Dueling Club rival stats). In a corridor, he waits for a teacher to walk round the corner, then plays innocent.
They accuse him (Day 4+)	"Me? I was in the Hospital Wing on the third night. Ask the matron. Ask anyone." He looks genuinely rattled.
They try to steal the map	DEX 15 and he is distracted. Fail: he catches their wrist and smiles. "Now we're talking."

IN CHARACTER: CASSIUS THORNE, DIAGON ALLEY

"First-years. Lovely. Try not to cry in the Great Hall this year."

IN CHARACTER: CASSIUS THORNE, DAY 4

"Finders keepers. Unless you've got something better."

Wren Ashby

A fourth-year Ravenclaw collector of Chocolate Frog cards and secrets.

Usually found	The Great Hall at Lunch, the Library in Free time, from Day 2.
How to play them	Talk fast about rarities. Ink-stained fingers. Lower your voice for gossip. Knows everyone's business.
What they want	One rare Chocolate Frog card to finish a set she has been building for three years.
What they hide	She knows who signed for the new portraits.

They show her any card	She identifies it instantly and tells them its value. Common ones she will swap for a sweet.
They bring the rare card	She pays with a secret: "It came with the new portraits. Ashgrove signed for it himself."
They try to trick her with a fake	INT 14 to make a convincing fake. She checks the back. She always checks the back.

IN CHARACTER: WREN ASHBY

"I'm missing one. A rare. Find it for me and I'll tell you something about the painting nobody else knows."

The covered painting (Corvin Vale)

The villain. A painter who sealed himself in his own canvas to live forever, and needs the light of the young to finish.

Usually found	The luggage car on the Express. From Day 1 Curfew, a cold dead-end corridor in the Undercroft.
How to play them	Velvet-soft, patient, never hurried. Speak in colours and brushstrokes. Always call students “child”. Never raise your voice. Ask questions instead of answering them.
What they want	To finish his self-portrait and live forever.
What they hide	Everything. Before Day 5, he barely speaks: he is watching, learning their names, deciding which one to tempt.

They come near it (Day 1–4)	Cold air, the faint smell of turpentine. Something under the cloth breathes.
They speak to it	“Not yet, child. Not yet.” Nothing more until Day 5.
The Quill comes near it	The Quill feels its eyes follow them. Tell the Quill privately. Nobody else notices anything.
They attack it	See “The covered painting and spells” in Part 1. Nothing works. Nothing is meant to, yet.

IN CHARACTER: THE COVERED PAINTING, IF ANYONE IS CLOSE ENOUGH TO HEAR

“You have such bright eyes, child. Keep them open.”

Prologue faces

Who	Voice	What makes the scene
Gringotts goblin	Curt, suspicious, prices everything with his eyes.	He glances at the Marlowe’s serpent key and says nothing. A WIS 13 check: he has seen that crest before, on a vault nobody has opened in three hundred years.
Mr Ollivander	Soft, wide-eyed, appears without a sound.	He remembers every wand he ever sold. To the Marlowe: “I sold your great-grandfather a wand of yew and serpent scale. It did terrible things. I do hope you do better.”
The trolley witch	Cheerful, sing-song, sixty years on this train.	About the last carriage: “Oh, don’t go back there, dear. Some delivery for the school. Gave me the shivers, and I’ve carried a dragon egg on this train.”

PART 2

Spotlighting each family

Every player should have a moment that only they could have.

Each family has a gift and a secret. Here is where each one shines between the Prologue and Day 4, so that by the end of Day 4 every player has had a scene that was about them.

Family	Their moment (Days 0–4)	Their secret pays off
Blackwood	Ask any portrait one question. Best on Day 3: ask a portrait in the library corridor what it saw. It answers truthfully and is terrified: “A painted man, climbing out.”	The grandmother’s diary mentions “the painted man”. When the name Vale appears (Day 4), the Blackwood recognises the debt.
Sinclair	Day 2, Curfew: the sister is drained. Everything about that scene belongs to the Sinclair. Let them choose first.	The sister’s warning letter. On Day 3, “Canvas” is whispered to them.
Fenwick	The Torn Edge puzzle any time from Day 1. Day 4: Cassius has the other half.	Opening the map by voice is the best moment in the first half. Make the table go quiet for it.
Thornbury	Care of Magical Creatures (Day 3), and Bramble in the forest. Creatures never attack first: let the Thornbury walk where others cannot.	Bramble calling from the forest. Day 3 onwards she is findable.
Quill	The covered painting’s eye on the train. Day 1 Curfew: the dream of the painted eye. Ask “What here is hidden or enchanted?” in Ashgrove’s classroom: “Every painting. All of them.”	They see what nobody else sees. Make sure the table hears it from them, not from you.
Marlowe	Parseltongue. The Grand Staircase has a carved serpent on one banister that hisses back. Snakes in the grounds can scout for them.	The serpent key. If they find the stair behind the Dungeons fireplace early, the door opens for them, and only them.
Hale	Healer’s Hands. Day 2 Curfew: when the prefect is drained, the Hale can read the injury: “She isn’t hurt. She’s been emptied.”	The casebook patient whispered “Vale”. The first time the Hale sees a drained student, they recognise it.
Penrose	Metamorphmagus. Wear a prefect’s face to get into the Restricted Section, or Filch’s to scare Peeves. Their hair changes colour when they lie: tell the table.	The great-great-grandmother’s missing portrait is one of Vale’s, somewhere in the castle. Hang it in Ashgrove’s classroom on Day 4 and let them find it.
Okafor	Curse-Breaker. Feel the curse on the covered painting. Open the cursed chest safely. Break the curse on the Restricted Section gate.	Their mother wrote “Occupied” on the painting. When they touch the covered painting, they feel exactly what she felt.

TIP

Keep a sticky note per player. Every time they have a spotlight moment, put a tick on it. At the end of Day 2, give the next scene to whoever has the fewest ticks.

PART 3

The Prologue

From an owl at the window to the first night in a common room.

The Prologue is four blocks on the clock: Letters arrive, Gringotts and Diagon Alley, the Hogwarts Express, and the Welcome Feast. It is the part of the game where the players learn that this world answers back. Everything they poke here should feel wonderful, and nothing should be dangerous yet. Save the fear for the castle.

TIP

The Prologue has no house points (nobody is sorted yet), so your rewards are Galleons, sweets and attention. A player who does something charming in Diagon Alley should get a moment in the spotlight for it.

Scene 1: The letter

ON THE GM SCREEN

The opening cutscene ends on the family page. When everyone has a family, Close the book. Table tab: choose Home, Just show on TV.

READ ALOUD

Somewhere in Britain, on an ordinary morning at the end of summer, an owl lands where no owl should be. It is carrying a heavy envelope of yellowish parchment, addressed in emerald-green ink to someone who has never had a letter in their life. Or who has had hundreds, and none like this.

Go round the table. The DM Guide has vignettes for the first six families. Here are the three newer ones.

Hale

READ ALOUD

The owl lands on the windowsill of the consulting room while your mother is setting a broken wrist. She doesn't even look up. "Open it, then. Carefully, it's probably sealed with a charm." It is. It smells faintly of St Mungo's: clean linen and something green. Behind you, on the shelf, your great-grandmother's casebook sits where it always sits. Today, for no reason, it has fallen open.

Penrose

READ ALOUD

The owl arrives in the middle of a rehearsal and lands on the leading actor, who is your uncle, who is currently wearing the face of a king. Everyone stops. Your hair goes bright purple with excitement before you can stop it. Your grandmother reads the letter over your shoulder and says, "Hogwarts. Good. And for heaven's sake, child, arrive looking like yourself."

Okafor

READ ALOUD

The owl taps at the workshop window, and your dad, a Muggle engineer, still jumps every single time. Your mum takes the letter from its leg without a word and runs her fingers over the wax seal, checking it for curses out of habit. Then she smiles and gives it to you. Later that night you hear her on the Floo, arguing with someone at Gringotts about a painting. She sounds frightened. She never sounds frightened.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

For each player: "Tell us one thing about you that nobody at Hogwarts knows yet." Write the answers down. You will use them all week.

They want to write back	Lovely. Their owl takes it. On Day 1 an owl brings a reply from home: a parent's voice in two lines. Write it yourself with the Owl Post tab.
They read their family secret aloud	Let them. Some players love to share. Then ask the table: "Does anyone else's family have a story like that?"
They try magic at home	Underage magic outside school: an owl from the Ministry arrives within a minute with a stern warning. It is funny, not a punishment.

Scene 2: Gringotts

ON THE GM SCREEN

Day & class tab: Advance time. Table tab: choose Gringotts, tick everyone, Move them here. Then open each vault from the Players tab.

READ ALOUD

At the top of Diagon Alley stands a snowy-white building with bronze doors. Inside, the hall is marble and silence, and a hundred goblins sit at high desks weighing jewels and writing in ledgers, and every one of them looks up at you at once.

IN CHARACTER: GRINGOTTS GOBLIN

"Vault keys. Or account names. Quickly."

Family	Vault	Say this as the door opens
Hale	240 Galleons	“Neat stacks of gold, and a Wiggenweld Potion your parents left on top with a note: Use it on someone else first.”
Penrose	180 Galleons	“Gold, three theatre masks, and a costume nobody has worn in a hundred years.”
Okafor	280 Galleons	“Gold, and a small brass curse-breaker’s pick your mum left for you. She would say it’s for emergencies. She would mean always.”

The other six vaults are in the DM Guide.

They ride the mine cart	Of course they do. A goblin takes them down. It is fast, it is dark, it is the best thing that has ever happened to them. Anyone who rolls a natural 1 on a CON check is sick on arrival.
They ask about other vaults	“Gringotts does not discuss other customers.” A WIS 13 check notices one vault door covered in dust, with a serpent on the lock. The goblin sees them notice.
They try to steal	There is no surer way to die. The goblin smiles with every one of his teeth. Do not let it get further than the thought.
The Marlowe shows the serpent key	The goblin goes very still. “That key does not open anything at Gringotts.” Pause. “Anymore.”

Scene 3: Diagon Alley

ON THE GM SCREEN

Header: Open shops. Move everyone to Diagon Alley. The Shop tab on their phones ticks off the school list.

READ ALOUD

Diagon Alley swallows you whole. Cauldrons stacked outside shops, owls hooting in cages, a witch selling eyeballs by the jar, bunting strung between crooked chimneys. Every window wants you. At the far end of the street, a narrow, dusty shop has a single wand on a faded cushion in its window.

Let them split up and shop. While they are busy with their phones, walk around and give each small group a moment:

They look in the bookshop	A book of monsters tries to bite them. A book of jokes laughs at its own jokes. A heavy book called “Painters of the Enchanted Canvas” is on the bargain table, and the shopkeeper says it has been returned three times.
They visit the pet shop	Something in the back is purring very loudly. Every animal turns to look at the Thornbury. A toad escapes.
They open barrels outside the apothecary	Beetle eyes, a Sickle a scoop. Dragon liver, not for children. One barrel is labelled “DO NOT OPEN” and has a small voice inside it saying “please open”. (It is a Fanged Frisbee. It goes for their ankles: DEX 10 or 1 HP.)
They try to buy something not on the list	If it is reasonable, it exists. Price it at 3–10 Galleons and give the item, or a custom item with a name. A broomstick is 50 Galleons and first-years cannot have one at school.
They help someone who can’t afford their list	Remember it. At the feast, or at the first chance once sorted, give the helper +5 house points.
They are rude to a shopkeeper	The price goes up by a Galleon, and the shopkeeper tells the next shop.

The rival

READ ALOUD

Outside the pet shop, an older boy in expensive robes is leaning against the wall, tossing a Galleon. He looks at you like you are something on his shoe.

IN CHARACTER: CASSIUS THORNE

"First-years. Lovely. Try not to cry in the Great Hall this year."

They answer back	He smiles slowly. "Oh, I'm going to enjoy this year." He remembers their name.
They ignore him	He says the Marlowe's surname loudly as he passes, so the whole street turns. Then he is gone.
They hex him	He blocks it with a flick (he is three years older). "Cute." A shopkeeper shouts. No points yet: nobody is sorted.

Scene 4: Ollivanders

READ ALOUD

A bell tinkles somewhere deep in the shop. The place smells of dust and old wood. Thousands of narrow boxes are piled to the ceiling, and some of them hum. Then an old man with wide, pale eyes is simply there, as if he has been standing behind the counter all along.

IN CHARACTER: MR OLLIVANDER

"Ah. I wondered when I would be seeing you."

One student at a time. The Wand questions are on the Players tab; each student gets a different random set. Read them in his voice, and read his reply to each answer from the purple box on the GM panel or the Ceremony Book. While one student answers, the others will poke at the shop:

They open wand boxes	Every box they open, the wand inside does something: a shower of sparks, a vase explodes, their hair turns blue. Spin the Wand misfire wheel for fun.
They climb the ladder	The ladder slides along the shelves by itself and stops exactly where Ollivander wants it. He does not turn round. "Third box from the left, if you would."
They ask about Vale	He goes quiet. "I sold a wand once to a painter. Rowan and unicorn hair. A gentle wand. He did not use it gently." That is all.
The Marlowe gets their wand	Ollivander says the line about the great-grandfather and the yew wand. Let it hang.

READ ALOUD

"Curious," Ollivander murmurs, as the wand warms in your hand. "The wand chooses the wizard, you see. It is not always clear why. But I think we can expect great things from you. Or terrible ones. Often it is the same thing."

Scene 5: The platform and the train

ON THE GM SCREEN

Advance time to The Hogwarts Express. Move everyone to Platform Nine and Three-Quarters first, then to the Express.

READ ALOUD

King's Cross, eleven o'clock, and there is no platform nine and three-quarters. There is platform nine. There is platform ten. Between them is a solid brick barrier, and a family with an owl cage has just walked straight into it and vanished.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

"How do you get through?" The Quill has no idea. Whoever explains it to the Quill earns the first kindness of the campaign.

They walk at it slowly	They bump their nose. It is brick. You have to mean it.
They run at it	Steam, noise, a scarlet engine. They are through.
The Penrose changes face to look older	A guard waves them through without a ticket check. Nobody asked for one anyway.

READ ALOUD

The train pulls out of the station and the city falls away into green hills. You have a compartment to yourselves. Somewhere down the corridor, a trolley is rattling closer.

The Express is the first place they can roam. Here is everything on it:

The trolley	"Anything from the trolley, dears?" Chocolate Frogs, Pumpkin Pasties, Bertie Bott's Beans, a Galleon each. Give the item and take the gold.
Other compartments	Roll a d6: 1 a toad, escaped; 2 older students playing Exploding Snap (it explodes); 3 a girl reading upside down; 4 Prefect Sinclair; 5 Cassius and two friends; 6 an empty compartment, very cold, the window frosted on a summer day.
The luggage racks	Trunks, cages, a broomstick someone smuggled. A small find if they search.
Prefect Sinclair	She introduces herself and checks on her sibling. If the Sinclair talks to her alone, she admits the bad dreams.
Cassius	He passes their compartment and greets the Marlowe by surname, loudly, for the whole carriage.
The window	Hills, then mountains, then a lake. At dusk, the first sight of a castle on a cliff, every window lit.
Pulling the emergency brake	Do not let it work. The handle is enchanted and simply goes "no" in a polite voice.

The last carriage

IN CHARACTER: THE TROLLEY WITCH

"Oh, don't go back there, dear. Some delivery for the school. Gave me the shivers, and I've carried a dragon egg on this train."

READ ALOUD

Between the luggage racks of the last carriage, something large leans against the wall, wrapped in grey cloth and tied with cord. A painting, by the shape of it. There is no label. The cold in this carriage is the kind you feel in your teeth.

Only the Quill sees the eye. Tell them alone, or quietly:

READ ALOUD

The cloth has slipped at one corner. Through the gap, you see a painted eye. It blinks. It follows you as you step back. When you look again, the cloth is in place, as if it never moved.

The Okafor touches it	Their Curse-Breaker sense goes off like an alarm: something in there is alive, and very old, and paying attention. Exactly what their mother felt.
The Blackwood asks it a question (Portrait Whisperer)	It does not answer. That has never happened before. Every Blackwood portrait has always answered.
Anyone tries to unwrap it	See Part 1, the covered painting and spells. The cord is iron-tight.
They tell Prefect Sinclair	She goes pale, then laughs it off. "Probably a portrait of some old headmaster." She checks it herself later. She does not laugh about it again.

Scene 6: The Sorting

ON THE GM SCREEN

Advance time to The Welcome Feast. Move everyone to The Great Hall. The Sorting Hat is on the Players tab, one student at a time. Each student hears five different questions; the Hat's reply to every answer is in the purple box on the GM panel and in the Ceremony Book.

READ ALOUD

The boats cross a black lake under a sky full of stars, and Hogwarts rises above you, every window lit. Inside is a hall so tall that its ceiling is the night sky itself. Thousands of candles float in the air. Four long tables full of students fall silent, and on a stool at the front sits a battered, patched old hat.

Sort in alphabetical order by family name: Blackwood, Fenwick, Hale, Marlowe, Okafor, Penrose, Quill, Sinclair, Thornbury. The Hat's song is in the DM Guide.

They argue with the Hat	The Hat enjoys it. "Oh, a debater. Ravenclaw would love you. Or Slytherin would use you." The argument counts as the house wish.

They try to cheat the questions	The Hat knows. “You are answering what you think I want to hear. Which tells me rather a lot.”
A Penrose changes face under the Hat	The Hat laughs out loud. “I see under faces, child. That’s rather the point of me.” The hall laughs too. Good laughter.
Two friends want the same house	Let the wish matter. The Hat says so out loud: “Loyalty to a friend. Noted.”

READ ALOUD

The Hat shouts the name of your house, and one of the four tables explodes into applause. You stumble to your seat, your ears still ringing.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Each sorting shows a crest reveal on the TV. Their house specialty (Gryffindor Nerve, Ravenclaw Wit, Slytherin Cunning, Hufflepuff Steadfast) switches on and appears on their phone’s Sheet.

The Welcome Feast

READ ALOUD

Golden plates fill with food out of nowhere. Ghosts drift through the tables. When the last plate has cleared itself, the Headmaster rises, and the hall falls silent.

IN CHARACTER: THE HEADMASTER

“Welcome, all. A few notices. The Forbidden Forest is forbidden: the name was a clue. Curfew is at nine. Mr Filch reminds you that he has keys to every door in this castle. And this year we have a gift: Professor Ashgrove, our new Defence teacher, has generously added to the castle’s collection of portraits. Do say hello to them. Most of them like to talk.”

They watch the staff table	Ashgrove laughs with everyone. Grimsby eats alone and looks at no one. Vance taps her glass once. Flitwick is standing on his chair to see. A WIS 14 check: Ashgrove keeps glancing at the floor, as if listening to something underneath it.
They talk to the ghosts	The ghost asks politely whether they have seen a large painting arrive. She seems relieved when they have not, and worried when they have.
They try to sneak out of the feast	Prefects herd first-years like sheep. A DEX 15 gets them as far as the Entrance Hall, where Filch is waiting, delighted.
They eat everything	Let them. Ask what their favourite dish is. It appears on their plate, twice.

Scene 7: The first night

ON THE GM SCREEN

Table tab: Send all staff to their rooms. Then Lights out sends everyone to their own common room. Advance time when you are ready: the first school day begins.

Every common room has its own way in. Make each house do theirs once, in front of everyone. It makes the houses feel real.

House	The way in	If they get it wrong
Gryffindor	The Fat Lady's portrait asks for the password. A prefect tells them on the first night.	She refuses and sings at them until they leave.
Ravenclaw	No password: a bronze eagle knocker asks a riddle. Make one up, or use: "What has a neck but no head?" (A bottle.)	The knocker asks another. They can wait for someone cleverer.
Hufflepuff	Tap the right barrel near the kitchens, twice, then once, in the right rhythm.	The wrong barrel sprays them with vinegar.
Slytherin	Say the password to a bare stone wall in the dungeons.	Nothing. The wall waits. The lake sloshes behind it.

They explore the common room	See Part 5 for each room. Every common room has someone in it with gossip: spin Portrait gossip, or tell them a rumour about the new paintings.
They sneak out on night zero	Nothing is hunting yet, but Filch is. Spin Out after curfew. It is a great way to get detention on the first night and start The Old Cup early.
They go to bed	Ask each player one question: "What do you dream about?" The Quill dreams of a painted eye. Tell them so.

PART 4

Days 1 to 4

Twenty blocks. Two victims. One name.

Each day has five blocks: Morning class, Lunch, Afternoon class, Free time and Curfew. For every block this part tells you **who is where** (the app moves them for you), **what appears** (also automatic), what to read, how to run the class if there is one, and what your players are likely to try. By the end of Day 4 they should have met everyone, used their spells, solved two or three puzzles, found a dozen clues and be arguing about who did it.

> **ON THE GM SCREEN**
>
> Advance time on the Day & class tab moves the whole castle. Each new morning, the end-of-day ceremony plays on the TV by itself (house race, House of the Day, awards). Press Back to the map when you are done with it.

How to run a free block

- Read the block's opening line. Ask: "Where do you go?"
- If they split up, run one group for a couple of minutes, then switch. End each switch on a small cliffhanger.
- Use the party panel on the right of the GM screen: tap a student's card to look at their room without changing the TV.
- When a block has run its course, or the table goes quiet, advance time. Do not wait for them to do everything. The castle does not wait.

How to run a class

- Read the professor's opening (below). Tick who is there and press Start class minigame.
- While they play, do the professor's voice: encouraging, scathing, distracted, whatever fits. Call out names.
- When someone passes: one line of praise from the professor and a house point or two if they were stylish.
- When someone fails twice: one line of sympathy, and a promise. "See me after class." Then actually do it in Free time: a second chance costs them a scene.
- Anyone who skipped class misses the lesson. The professor notices. Next time they see that student, they say so.

DAY 1

Welcome to Hogwarts

First lessons, a furious potions master, and something hung in the dark.

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	Charms with Flitwick. Teaches Lumos.	Charms classroom
Lunch	Prefect Sinclair offers Keep an Eye Out.	Great Hall
Afternoon class	Potions with Grimsby. Teaches Pepperup Potion (2).	Dungeons
Free time	Grimsby's cupboard raided: Stolen Ingredients.	Dungeons
Curfew	Beat: the covered painting is hung below the castle. Cornish Pixies on the Grand Staircase.	Anywhere

Day 1, Morning class: Charms

Where	Who is there
Charms classroom	Flitwick
Entrance Hall	Filch, the ghost
Grand Staircase	Peeves
Elsewhere	Every professor in their own room, Pip in the Kitchens, the librarian, the matron

Appears this morning: the three ring clues (Trophy Room, Astronomy Tower, Owlery), the first rune tablet (Library), and five chests: a Locked chest in the Library, a Small chest in the Owlery, a Locked chest on the Astronomy Tower, an Ancient chest in the Room of Requirement and a Small chest in the Kitchens.

READ ALOUD

You wake to a grey morning and the smell of toast. Somewhere, a staircase is grinding into a new position. Your timetable says Charms, first thing, and you have no idea where the Charms classroom is.

They get lost on the way	Spin Hogwarts surprises. Anything that happens on the way is a free scene. If they are late, Flitwick forgives them once, beaming.
They ask a portrait for directions	The portraits on the Grand Staircase argue with each other about the route. One points the wrong way on purpose and giggles.
They skip class to explore	Let them. They miss Lumos, which they will want in the dark later. Flitwick is crestfallen when he next sees them.
They meet Peeves on the stairs	"Ickle firsties!" He drops a water balloon on the slowest one. DEX 10 to dodge, or arrive at Charms soaked.

READ ALOUD

The Charms classroom is all tiered desks and floating feathers. At the front, on a tall stack of books, stands a very small professor with an enormous smile. "Welcome, welcome! Wands out! Today: light. The first spell, the oldest spell, and the one you will use most in your lives. Lumos!"

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR FLITWICK

"Swish and flick! It is all in the wrist, and a little in the heart. Try again, try again!"

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Wand Motion). Passing teaches Lumos and gives 10 XP.

Someone casts Lumos brilliantly	Flitwick claps so hard he falls off his books. +5 house points.
Someone fails twice	"See me in Free time, dear. Everyone gets it in the end." If they go, he teaches them in two minutes. Give the spell from the Spells tab.
They poke around the classroom	Feathers float everywhere from a levitation class. A globe spins by itself. A chest under the window is locked and full of confiscated items (Hard DEX: a Dungbomb and a love letter).

Day 1, Lunch

Where	Who is there
Great Hall	The Headmaster, every professor, Peeves, the ghost, Prefect Sinclair, Cassius Thorne
Entrance Hall	Filch
Elsewhere	Pip in the Kitchens, the librarian, the matron

READ ALOUD

The Great Hall at lunchtime is noise and steam and owls dropping post into the soup. At the staff table, Professor Ashgrove is telling a story that has three professors laughing. At the end of the table, Professor Grimsby eats alone and looks at nobody.

This is the block where they meet everyone. Every staff member is in the room. Let them talk to as many as they like.

IN CHARACTER: PREFECT SINCLAIR

"I'm probably being silly. But the castle feels wrong this year. If you're out after dinner, meet me by the Grand Staircase. I want to show you something."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Quests tab: give Keep an Eye Out to whoever accepts (at least the Sinclair). If nobody meets her by Day 2 Free time, she sends it by owl.

They talk to Ashgrove	He knows their names already. He asks each of them one question about themselves and remembers the answer all week. Everyone should like him. That is the point.
They talk to Grimsby	"Hm." He does not look up. If they persist: "You have twenty minutes to eat. I suggest you use them."
They talk to the Headmaster	His welcome line. He asks how they are settling in and seems to really want to know.
Cassius picks on someone	He flicks a pea at the Quill, or says the Marlowe's name loudly. A teacher is watching: if they retaliate with magic, −5 points.
They search the Great Hall	Under the tables: chewing gum from 1890. Behind the staff table: a door to a small chamber where the staff meet. It is locked. Through the keyhole, a painting of a sunlit garden that Ashgrove hung last week.

Day 1, Afternoon class: Potions

Where	Who is there
The Dungeons	Grimsby
Trophy Room	Filch
The Library	Peeves, the librarian
Grand Staircase	the ghost
Forbidden Forest	the centaur
Elsewhere	Every other professor in their room

READ ALOUD

The dungeons are cold enough to see your breath. Jars line the walls: things floating in green liquid, things that might once have had eyes. Professor Grimsby does not look up when you come in.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR GRIMSBY

"Sit. Open your books. If anyone's cauldron explodes, they clean it up themselves."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Stir Timing). Passing gives two Pepperup Potions and 10 XP.

Someone does well	Grimsby looks at the cauldron for a long moment. "Adequate." From him, that is a medal. +5 points if they deserve it.
Someone's cauldron explodes	Spin Potion brewing for what it does. They clean it up themselves, as promised.
They read the jars	Most are ingredients. One is labelled "Boomslang skin" and is nearly empty. Another, "Lacewing flies", is empty. Grimsby has not noticed yet.
They ask Grimsby a question	"Hm." If it is a good question about potions, he answers it properly, and seems annoyed that he enjoyed it.

Day 1, Free time

Where	Who is there
The Dungeons	Grimsby (furious)
Grand Staircase	Peeves, the ghost, Prefect Sinclair
The Courtyard	Cassius
Trophy Room	Filch
Forbidden Forest	the centaur
Elsewhere	Professors in their rooms, Pip, the librarian, the matron

Appears: the stolen ingredient jars, hidden on the Grand Staircase.

READ ALOUD

A crash echoes from the dungeons, then a voice you already recognise, very loud: "WHO HAS BEEN IN MY CUPBOARD?" Students scatter. Professor Grimsby storms up the corridor with his robes flapping, glaring at every first-year he passes.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR GRIMSBY

"Somebody has been in my store cupboard. Boomslang skin. Lacewing flies. Gone. If I find out it was a first-year, they will be scrubbing cauldrons until they are forty."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Give Stolen Ingredients to anyone who offers to help. Pin "Grimsby's store cupboard was raided" under Grimsby when they look at the cupboard.

This is the first big free block. Here is everything they can do:

They search the store cupboard	INT 12: sticky fingerprints, too big for a student and slightly see-through. A trail of lacewing wings leads up the stairs. (It is Peeves.)
They follow the trail to the Grand Staircase	Peeves is there, juggling. The jars are on a landing above. To get them: corner Peeves (DEX or CHA 13), or Wingardium Leviosa, or climb a moving staircase (DEX 12, a fall is 2 HP).
They meet Prefect Sinclair at the staircase	Keep an Eye Out, step 1. She is early and nervous. She says she will show them the bad corridor tonight, after curfew.
They go to the Library	The first rune tablet is on a reading desk (pick it up from the Here tab). The Locked chest is by the windows. The librarian watches.
The Fenwick studies the map	Put The Torn Edge on the TV. It is a lovely first puzzle and teaches the first runes.
They visit the Trophy Room	Filch is polishing. The Scratched note (first ring clue) is tucked behind a cup. A WIS 12 notices it before he does.
They climb to the Owlery or the Astronomy Tower	A ring clue in each, and a chest. Nothing in the clues makes sense yet. That is fine.
They find the Kitchens	Tickle the pear. Pip feeds them. The Small chest is by the ovens.
They go to the Forest	Out of bounds. The centaur is there, speaking to the sky. Spin the Forest wheel.

The mirror in the Library

Whenever the party is in the Library during Free time (or you steer them there: a rumour that the tall mirror at the end of the stacks shows you your future), run **The Mirror in the Dark**. It is the big moment of Day 1: every house has to work together, and it uses the Lumos they learned that morning (without telling them so). Everything you need is in the Props Book chapter of the same name and in the DM Guide.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *At the far end of the Library, past the last shelf, stands a mirror taller than a door. Your reflections look back at you, but a moment late. As you lean closer, the glass ripples like water.*

Professor Greaves and his cards

In the same Library, behind a velvet curtain, Professor Greaves of Divination reads the future for **20 Galleons**, **one reading per house per day**. You do the reading for real with your own deck; the app writes what Greaves says and decides the reward or curse. The rules and every favour and curse are in the DM Guide, **Tarot in the Library**. This is how to handle the cards themselves.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *Behind a curtain of dusty velvet, in an alcove that smells of candle smoke and old paper, a tall man sits very still with a deck of cards under his hand. He does not look up. "Twenty Galleons," he says, "and one of you at a time."*

Before the session (once)

- **Check the deck.** Count the 78 cards. Take out any extras: a title card, an instructions card, a spare.
- **Turn every card the same way up.** A new deck comes all upright, so it would never deal a reversed card. Start from all upright so the only reversals are the ones your shuffle makes.
- **Make reversals possible.** Split the deck roughly in half, turn one half round (top to bottom, still face down), and shuffle the halves together. Do it two or three times. About half the cards are now upside down, at random.
- **Learn your deck's names.** Horror decks often rename things: Coins or Disks are **Pentacles**, Staves or Rods are **Wands**, Princess and Prince are **Page** and **Knight**. On the Tarot tab, pick cards by name, not number; some decks swap Strength and Justice (VIII and XI).

The reading, step by step

- **1. Set the scene.** Take their 20 Galleons in the story. Lower your voice. You are Greaves now. A candle or a dark cloth on the table helps.
- **2. Shuffle in front of them.** Best is the *wash*: spread the cards face down and swirl them round the table with both hands. It mixes which way up they are, looks eerie, and is kind to the cards. Gather and square the deck. An overhand shuffle is fine too; avoid bending riffles.
- **3. Let them cut.** The student cuts the deck with their **left hand** into three piles and stacks them back in any order. Their hands decide the cards, so nobody can say you stacked it.
- **4. Deal three cards face down**, left to right: **Past**, **Present**, **Future**.
- **5. Turn them over one at a time, sideways.** This is the important bit. Flip each card from its side, like turning a page of a book, never top to bottom (that turns it upside down and changes whether it is reversed). A card is **reversed** if it is upside down **as you look at it** from your side of the table. Keep that rule all night.

- **6. Enter each card as you turn it.** On the **Tarot** tab, pick the student, then the card, and tick **Reversed** if it is upside down. Read Greaves's line for that card before you turn the next.
- **7. Pause before the Future card.** The tab already shows you the outcome at the top, so you can play it up. Look the student in the eye. Then turn it.
- **8. Read the verdict, then press Seal the reading.** The TV deals the three cards and shows the result, so the table sees it land just after you have said it. The favour or curse appears on their phone.

After each reading

- Put the three cards back and wash the deck again before the next reading. Do not turn them upright: the reversals stay random.
- If a card jumps out of the deck while you shuffle, readers say it "wants to be seen". Greaves can frown at it and say something ominous. Pure flavour.

Future card upright (about half the time)	**Fortune's Favour.** One upper hand, used once.
Future card reversed (about half the time)	**Nothing.** The Galleons are gone.
All three upright (about 1 in 8)	**Blessed.** Two favours.
All three reversed (about 1 in 8)	**Cursed.** Harsh, on purpose. They chose to look.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR GREAVES

"Every card upright. In thirty years I have seen this perhaps a dozen times. Go, child, before the castle changes its mind."

TIP

Greaves is a showman. Take your time with each card, and for a curse, do not apologise much. Just go very quiet, and slide the cards away from them.

TIP

Day 1 Free time is the best moment to show them how big the world is. If they only do the quest, describe what they pass on the way: an owl with a parcel too heavy for it, a ghost crying in a corridor, a portrait of a knight challenging them to a duel.

Day 1, Curfew

Where	Who is there
Grand Staircase	Filch, Peeves, Prefect Sinclair (patrolling)
The Library	the ghost
Forbidden Forest	the centaur
Elsewhere	Pip in the Kitchens, the matron

Appears: a swarm of Cornish Pixies on the Grand Staircase (they leave when the block ends).

ON THE GM SCREEN

Anyone who moves around spins Out after curfew. A group that meets the prefect can travel with her, and Filch will not spin for them while she is there.

Keep an Eye Out: the patrol

READ ALOUD

Prefect Sinclair is waiting at the foot of the Grand Staircase, wand lit, pretending she isn't nervous. "Quietly," she whispers. She leads you down a corridor you have never seen. Every frame on the walls is empty. Painted chairs, painted gardens, painted skies, and nobody in any of them.

IN CHARACTER: PREFECT SINCLAIR

"They were all here last week. All of them. Now look." She stops at a dead end where the air is so cold your breath clouds. "That's where it's worst. Under there, somewhere."

They tap the wall at the dead end	It is cold, colder than stone should be. A WIS 14: faintly, from below, something humming.
The Okafor touches the wall	A curse, deep down, enormous and old. Like putting a hand on a sleeping animal.
The Pixies attack on the staircase	Four HP each, fast, annoying. They steal one small item each if not stopped. Good first fight. If Filch hears the fight: Out after curfew for everyone.
They sneak to the Kitchens	Pip is delighted. Midnight snacks. No danger at all.

The beat

READ ALOUD

Late that night, two figures carry something large and wrapped down a stairway that most students do not know exists. They hang it in a dead-end corridor deep under the castle. When they leave, the corridor is very, very quiet. Then the cloth stirs, though there is no wind.

Read this to the whole table, as a cutaway. Then, privately, to the Quill: they wake with a jolt from a dream of a painted eye.

DAY 2

The first victim

Mandrakes, a charming teacher, and a scream in the night.

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	Herbology with Longbottom. Teaches Mandrake care (1 Mandrake leaf).	Greenhouses
Lunch	Ashgrove shows off his portraits. Wren Ashby appears.	Defence classroom
Afternoon class	Defence with Ashgrove. Teaches Expelliarmus.	Defence classroom
Free time	Dueling Club sign-ups. The second rune tablet.	Great Hall
Curfew	Beat: Prefect Sinclair is found drained.	Ravenclaw Tower

Day 2, Morning class: Herbology

Where	Who is there
Greenhouses	Longbottom
Entrance Hall	Filch, the ghost
Grand Staircase	Peeves

READ ALOUD

Greenhouse Three is warm and damp and smells of earth. Professor Longbottom is up to his elbows in soil, laughing at something a plant has just done. On the benches, rows of pots. Something in one of them is crying.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR LONGBOTTOM

"Earmuffs on, everyone! These are Mandrakes. Their cry won't kill you at this age, but it'll ruin your afternoon. Gently does it."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Mandrake Repotting). Passing gives one Mandrake leaf and 10 XP. The leaves matter: Wake the Sleepers needs three.

Someone takes their earmuffs off	The Mandrake screams. CON 12 or Stunned for a round, and everyone laughs except them.
They poke the other plants	Something with teeth snaps (1 HP). Something else sneezes glittering pollen; they sneeze for an hour.
They help Longbottom tidy up	He chats happily and mentions the painting Ashgrove gave him for his office, "lovely thing". Nothing odd yet.

Day 2, Lunch

Where	Who is there
Great Hall	The Headmaster, most professors, Peeves, the ghost, Wren Ashby, Prefect Sinclair, Cassius
Defence classroom	Ashgrove, with his portraits
Entrance Hall	Filch

READ ALOUD

At lunch, a crowd of students has gathered at the door of the Defence classroom. Professor Ashgrove is showing them his paintings: landscapes, old wizards, a ship in a storm. He tells a story for every one. Everybody is laughing. In the back row of frames, one portrait is not.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR ASHGROVE

"I collect them! Every one has a story. Some of them are even true."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Pin "Ashgrove's classroom has more paintings every day" if the players count the frames, or come back tomorrow and notice more.

They count the paintings	Twenty-three. Tomorrow there will be twenty-six. Nobody sees him hang them.
The Quill asks what is hidden or enchanted	"Every painting in this room. All of them." Nothing more specific. The Quill feels watched by twenty-three pairs of eyes.
The Blackwood asks a portrait something	The portrait answers, but looks at Ashgrove first, as if for permission. That has never happened before.
They meet Wren Ashby in the Great Hall	She is sorting Chocolate Frog cards. Card Collector is on offer. She asks to see their cards.
They try to talk to Grimsby	He is reading a book on draughts and slams it shut.

Day 2, Afternoon class: Defence

Where	Who is there
Defence classroom	Ashgrove
The Dungeons	Grimsby, Peeves
Trophy Room	Filch
Grand Staircase	the ghost
Forbidden Forest	the centaur

READ ALOUD

Professor Ashgrove's classroom is warm and bright and full of paintings. He is the kind of teacher who remembers your name on the first day. He perches on the edge of his desk.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR ASHGROVE

"Defence is not about fighting. It is about making sure the fight never reaches you. Now. Wands up. Expelliarmus!"

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Duel Reflexes). Passing teaches Expelliarmus and 10 XP.

Someone does well	Ashgrove is delighted, warm, generous: +5 house points, and he says something kind and specific about them. They will remember it on Day 6.
Someone fails	He kneels beside them and helps, patiently. He is a genuinely good teacher. That is what makes it hurt later.
They look at the paintings during class	One painting's figure has turned its head to watch the student who is not paying attention. When they look straight at it, it is facing forward again.
They search his desk after class	He is still in the room, marking. DEX 15 to do it while he isn't looking. See his card in Part 2 for what is inside.

Day 2, Free time

Where	Who is there
Great Hall	Flitwick (Dueling Club), Cassius
The Library	the librarian, Wren Ashby
Grand Staircase	the ghost, Prefect Sinclair
The Courtyard	Peeves
Elsewhere	Professors in their rooms, Filch in the Trophy Room, the centaur in the Forest

Appears: a Dueling Club rival in the Great Hall (leaves at the end of the block), and the second rune tablet in the Greenhouses.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR FLITWICK

"Dueling Club! Every evening in the Great Hall. Fair fights, friendly spells, nobody gets stunned into next week. Well. Rarely."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Give Dueling Club Champion to anyone who signs up. The rival is already placed: start the fight from the Table tab. For a duel that feels like a duel, turn on the reaction duel on the rival's token.

They duel the rival	A fair fight with Expelliarmus fresh in their hands. Flitwick referees, squeaking advice. Winners get cheered; losers get a pat and a Chocolate Frog.
Cassius wants a go	He watches and sneers. If a student beats the rival, he says "Not bad. For a first-year." and walks off. He will be the final of the quest later.
Prefect Sinclair finds them	Last chance for Keep an Eye Out. She is more nervous than yesterday. "Tonight. I think something's going to happen tonight."
They go back to the Greenhouses	The second rune tablet is under a seed tray. Longbottom lets them keep it.

They visit the Library	Wren Ashby, the librarian, the Locked chest if nobody opened it. Searching for books on paintings: INT 12 finds “Portraiture, aisle nine”, and a note that the useful book is in the Restricted Section.

Day 2, Curfew: the first victim

Where	Who is there
Grand Staircase	Filch, Peeves
The Library	the ghost
Ravenclaw common room	Prefect Sinclair (drained)

ON THE GM SCREEN

Move every student who is out, and anyone in Ravenclaw Tower, to the Ravenclaw common room. Everyone else hears the scream from their common room: ask if they go. Place Prefect Sinclair on the map.

READ ALOUD

A scream echoes down the corridor outside Ravenclaw Tower. By the time you get there, a crowd of students in pyjamas is standing in a ring around someone lying very still on the flagstones.

It is the Sinclair prefect. Her eyes are open. She is breathing. But she is grey, all of her, as if someone has painted her in shades of ash. Her wand lies beside her hand, and when a teacher picks it up, it crumbles like charcoal.

Along the corridor walls, every portrait is empty.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

Look at the Sinclair player. “What do you do?” Then stop talking.

The Sinclair goes to her	She is cold. Her eyes do not follow anything. The teachers let the Sinclair stay with her until the matron arrives. Give them the moment. Do not rush it.
The Hale uses Healer’s Hands	They read the injury: “She isn’t hurt. She’s been emptied.” And then, from the casebook, the memory: this has happened before.
Someone looks at the empty frames	“Every portrait near an attack had gone silent.” Pin it under the covered painting.
Someone checks for footprints (Lumos)	None. But a smear of something on the edge of one empty frame: wet, dark red, like paint.
They accuse someone on the spot	The teachers send everyone to bed. Vance takes their name. The Headmaster looks at them for a long moment and says nothing.

ON THE GM SCREEN

After this scene, give everyone The Hollow Heir (the main quest). If you are ending the session here, this is the cliffhanger. If not, advance time when they go to bed.

DAY 3

Shadows in the library

A second victim, a draught, and a hippogriff.

TIP

If this is the start of a session, open with a recap: ask the players to tell you what has happened so far. Fill in only what they forget.

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	Transfiguration with Vance. Teaches Avifors.	Transfiguration classroom
Lunch	Beat: a second student drained in the Library. Wake the Sleepers.	Library, Hospital Wing
Afternoon class	Care of Magical Creatures with Scamander. Where is Bramble?	Gamekeeper's hut
Free time	The first diary page in the Restricted Section. A Thornback Boar in the Forest. The third rune tablet.	Anywhere
Curfew	The Hungry Trunk in the Trophy Room. Cassius in the Hospital Wing.	Anywhere

From today, many people have new things to say. Talking to people on Day 3 is where the mystery opens up: see the clue list in Part 6.

Day 3, Morning class: Transfiguration

Where	Who is there
Transfiguration classroom	Vance
Hospital Wing	the matron, Prefect Sinclair (drained)
Entrance Hall	Filch, the ghost
Grand Staircase	Peeves

READ ALOUD

The whole school is whispering. The Sinclair prefect is in the Hospital Wing. Nobody knows what happened. In Transfiguration, Professor Vance taps her wand on the desk once, and the whispering stops.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR VANCE

"I am aware of what happened last night. I am also aware that you are frightened. You will be less frightened if you can defend yourselves. Avifors. Pay attention."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Matching Pairs). Passing teaches Avifors and 10 XP.

They ask Vance whether paint can become real	"With enough power and enough time, anything can be made to become anything. That is precisely why we do not allow it."
They poke around her room	Beetles in cages, a tortoise that is half a teacup, a blackboard that corrects spelling by itself. The tortoise-teacup is very friendly.
They skip class to visit the Hospital Wing	The matron lets them in for a minute. If someone holds the prefect's hand, she whispers one word: "Canvas."

Day 3, Lunch: the second victim

Where	Who is there
The Library	the librarian, a drained fourth-year
Hospital Wing	Longbottom, the matron, Prefect Sinclair
Great Hall	The Headmaster, most professors, Peeves, the ghost, Wren Ashby, Cassius
Entrance Hall	Filch

READ ALOUD

A crowd at the Library door. The librarian is white with shock. Slumped against the shelves, a book still open in her lap, is a fourth-year girl. Grey, all of her. The portraits in this corridor are silent too, and one of them has a smear of fresh paint across its frame, as if something climbed out in a hurry.

They look closely at the victim	Eyes open. Wand crumbled to charcoal. On her fingertips, a smear of oil paint.
They read the book in her lap	"Lives of the Lesser Masters". It is open at a chapter on portrait painters. The next page has been torn out. (The torn page is in the Restricted Section.)
They look at the paint smear	Crimson and gold. Still wet. It smells of turpentine.
They go to the Hospital Wing	Longbottom is there, grey-faced, holding a Mandrake leaf.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR LONGBOTTOM

"There's a draught. A Restorative Draught. Old magic. It might bring them back. I'd need three Mandrake leaves, and someone with a steady hand at a cauldron."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Give Wake the Sleepers. Pin "Every portrait near an attack had gone silent" if not already. If they ask Longbottom what the victims had in common: "All of them were near a painting."

Who has something new to say today

Person	Ask them	They say
The Headmaster	Who could do this?	“Magic that drains and does not kill is old magic. Perhaps ask the portraits.”
Flitwick	The silent portraits	“Portraits go quiet when they are frightened. In fifty years I have only seen it twice.”
Filch	Where were you on night two?	“Supervising detention, weren’t I?” (Clears him.)
The ghost	Did you see anything?	“I saw a man step out of a frame.”
Grimsby	Do you know what is draining them?	“Hm. If I did…” His hands are shaking.
Pip	Have you heard anything?	“The portraits is whispering about a door that wants opening.”
Vance	Can paint become real?	“Anything can be made to become anything.”
Scamander	The forest	“Something under the castle is calling.”
The centaur	Anything	“Mars is bright tonight. Something old is waking beneath the stone.”

Day 3, Afternoon class: Care of Magical Creatures

Where	Who is there
The old gamekeeper’s hut	Scamander
The Library	Peeves, the librarian
Hospital Wing	the matron, the prefect
Trophy Room	Filch
Forbidden Forest	the centaur

READ ALOUD

Professor Scamander is waiting outside the old gamekeeper’s hut with a battered suitcase at her feet. Every so often, the suitcase thumps. “Creatures are not dangerous,” she says. “People who do not understand them are dangerous. Today we learn to understand.”

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Befriend the Beast). Passing gives two Creature treats and 10 XP.

IN CHARACTER: PROFESSOR SCAMANDER

To the Thornbury, after class: “A grey hippogriff at the edge of the forest. Proud. Torn tag on her leg. I believe she might be yours.”

ON THE GM SCREEN

Give Where is Bramble? to the Thornbury, and anyone who wants to go with them.

They ask what is in the suitcase	“Oh, don’t mind that. He’s shy.” The suitcase growls. Do not ever say what is in it.

They search around the hut	Pumpkins the size of armchairs, a crossbow nobody has used in years, a wheelbarrow full of something that moves. The third rune tablet is not here yet: it appears in Free time.

Day 3, Free time

Where	Who is there
Forbidden Forest	Scamander, the centaur
The Library	the librarian, Wren Ashby
Hospital Wing	Longbottom, the matron, the prefect
The Courtyard	Peeves, Cassius
Great Hall	Flitwick
Elsewhere	Professors in their rooms, Filch in the Trophy Room

Appears: the first page of Vale's diary in the Restricted Section, a Thornback Boar in the Forest (leaves at the end of the block), and the third rune tablet at the old gamekeeper's hut.

This is the busiest free block so far. The party will want to do four things at once. Let them split up.

They go after Bramble	Scamander and the centaur are in the Forest. Spin the Forest wheel. The boar is there: a real fight (22 HP). The Thornbury's Beast Bond means it does not attack them first. Bramble is deep in, afraid; Creature treats and the Thornbury's advantage calm her.
They try to get into the Restricted Section	See the Restricted Section in Part 5: a chained gate, an Alohomora-proof lock, a librarian with the key round her neck. Inside: the first diary page, and chained books that whisper.
They start brewing for Wake the Sleepers	They need three leaves. One from each Herbology pass, more from chests, or from Longbottom if they ask nicely (CHA 12: "Just one. Don't tell anyone.").
They talk to everyone with new lines	This is the block for it. Use the table above.
They visit the Hospital Wing	Two grey students now. The matron, exhausted. If they hold the prefect's hand: "Canvas."
They go back to the hut	The third rune tablet is by the door.

Day 3, Curfew

Where	Who is there
Trophy Room	Filch
Grand Staircase	Peeves
Restricted Section	the ghost
Hospital Wing	the matron, the prefect, Cassius (with a Bludger bruise)
Forbidden Forest	the centaur

Appears: the Hungry Trunk, a mimic, in the Trophy Room, looking exactly like a Locked chest.

They sneak out	Spin Out after curfew. Filch is in the Trophy Room tonight, so a detention tonight puts them in the same room as the mimic.

They open the chest in the Trophy Room	It is the Hungry Trunk. It springs. The jump scare plays. Real fight. Anything it swallows comes back when it is beaten.
They visit the Restricted Section at night	The ghost is there, reading over a student's shoulder who isn't there. She tells them about the man stepping out of a frame, if they haven't heard.
They visit the Hospital Wing	Cassius is in the bed by the window with a Bludger bruise, snoring. This is his alibi for tonight, if they think to remember it.
They try the dead end from Day 1	Colder than last night. The humming is louder.

DAY 4

The missing page

A name, a map, a broom, and a familiar face in the wrong place.

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	Potions with Grimsby. Teaches Wiggenweld Potion (2). The page about Vale is in the Restricted Section.	Dungeons
Lunch	Cassius with half an old map: The Other Half.	Courtyard
Afternoon class	Flying with Madam Hooch.	Quidditch Pitch
Free time	Beat: the page about Vale vanishes unless taken. The second diary page at the Black Lake.	Restricted Section, Black Lake
Curfew	The Painted Double, wearing a drained girl's face. Pixies in the Library.	Grand Staircase, Library

Day 4, Morning class: Potions

Where	Who is there
The Dungeons	Grimsby
Hospital Wing	the matron, the prefect
Entrance Hall	Filch, the ghost
Grand Staircase	Peeves

Appears: the Torn page about Corvin Vale, in the Restricted Section. It is there until Free time, then it vanishes.

READ ALOUD

Grimsby is in a worse mood than usual. His eyes are red. There is a cauldron in the corner covered with a cloth, and he moves between you and it every time someone gets close.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Stir Timing, harder). Passing gives two Wiggenweld Potions and 10 XP.

They try to look under the cloth	He slams the lid. "Not for you." WIS 14: the potion inside is the colour of dawn.
They ask him for help with the Restorative Draught	He freezes. Then: "Hm. Who told you about that?" If they say Longbottom, he sighs. "Then you will need lacewing that is not stolen." He gives them nothing yet, but he is listening.

TIP

The page about Vale is the big find of Day 4. If the players are not heading for the Restricted Section, use a nudge: the librarian is seen locking the gate in a hurry, or Peeves shrieks "Somebody's reading where they shouldn't!"

Day 4, Lunch: the other half

Where	Who is there
The Courtyard	Cassius, with half a map
Great Hall	The Headmaster, every professor, Peeves, the ghost, Wren Ashby
Hospital Wing	the matron, the prefect

READ ALOUD

Cassius is lounging on the courtyard wall, unfolding a piece of old parchment. It is torn straight down the middle, and the torn edge is exactly the same shape as the one in the Fenwick's pocket.

IN CHARACTER: CASSIUS THORNE

"Finders keepers. Unless you've got something better."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Give The Other Half to the Fenwick. Pin "Cassius was seen with half of an old map" under Cassius.

They try to buy it	He names a price that is too high (50 Galleons). He will haggle for a rare Chocolate Frog card, a secret, or a promise.
They challenge him to a duel for it	"Dueling Club. Tonight. Winner takes the map." A real duel with Dueling Club rival stats.
They try to steal it	DEX 15. If they fail, he catches their wrist: "Now we're talking." He respects it.
They trick him	A Penrose wearing a teacher's face can confiscate it. A good plan beats a roll: let it work.
They ask if he is behind the attacks	Before tonight he sneers. From today: "I was in the Hospital Wing on the third night. Ask the matron."

New things to say today

Person	Ask them	They say
The Headmaster	Have you heard of Corvin Vale?	A long pause. A painter. His predecessor's predecessor invited him to paint the staff.
Ashgrove	Corvin Vale	He lies. He touches his cuff. WIS 12 notices.
The ghost	Corvin Vale	"I knew him. He painted me, once."
Filch	The paintings	"New ones every week. I don't hang them."
Peeves	What have you seen?	"Painted man walking, painted man stalking, out of the frame and down to the deep!"
The matron	Cassius Thorne	"He was here on the third night. All night." (Clears him.)
The librarian	The missing page (after Free time)	"A page is torn from Lives of the Lesser Masters. If I find out who…"

Day 4, Afternoon class: Flying

Where	Who is there
Quidditch Pitch	Madam Hooch
The Library	Peeves, the librarian
Trophy Room	Filch
Grand Staircase	the ghost

READ ALOUD

The wind on the Quidditch pitch is sharp and smells of grass. Twenty school brooms lie in a row. Madam Hooch blows her whistle hard enough to rattle the stands.

IN CHARACTER: MADAM HOOCH

"Right hand over the broom and say UP! Not up, not please, UP! And if anyone flies into the hoops, I am not picking you up."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Start the class minigame (Broom Dodge). Passing gives the Broom flying perk and 10 XP.

Someone flies off on their own	Hooch blows her whistle until she is purple. −10 points. But from up there, they see something: a light moving in the Forest, or smoke from a chimney nobody uses. Give them one thing they could not see from the ground.
Someone falls	2 HP, and Hooch says "Up. Again." +5 points if they get straight back on.
They fly to the Owlery or the Astronomy Tower	Madam Hooch: "The Astronomy Tower to the Owlery in a minute flat. Not that I'm telling first-years that." It is a shortcut for later.

Day 4, Free time: the missing page

Where	Who is there
The Library	the librarian, Wren Ashby
Hospital Wing	Longbottom, the matron, the prefect
The Courtyard	Peeves, Cassius
The old gamekeeper's hut	Scamander
Forbidden Forest	the centaur
Elsewhere	Professors in their rooms, Filch in the Trophy Room

Changes: the Torn page about Corvin Vale vanishes from the Restricted Section (unless a player already picked it up). The second page of Vale's diary appears at the Black Lake.

If they already have the page

READ ALOUD

The page is old and brittle. Most of it is about a painter named Corvin Vale, who lived three hundred years ago and painted portraits so lifelike that people said his subjects sometimes left their frames. In his last years he became obsessed with one idea: that a painting never grows old. The final line has been underlined so hard that the quill tore through the paper: "I will finish myself."

If they did not take it in time

READ ALOUD

The shelf where the book lay is empty. On the floor, a single torn corner of yellowed paper, and a smear of crimson paint on the shelf edge. Somebody got here first.

Not getting the page is not a dead end: the name Vale still comes from the ghost, the Headmaster, and on Day 6 the Three Broomsticks.

They go to the Black Lake	The second diary page is tucked under a stone on the jetty, the ink half-washed. Something large moves under the water and does not surface.
They finish Bramble	This is the last block Scamander offers it. If they bring Bramble out of the Forest, she is safe in a paddock behind the hut, and remembers them.
They go back to Ashgrove's classroom	Twenty-six paintings now. A new one by the door: a young woman in old-fashioned clothes. If they have a Penrose: it is the great-great-grandmother, her face frozen.
They brew the Restorative Draught	If they have three Mandrake leaves: INT check or spin Potion brewing. Grimsby might help, if they asked him this morning.

Day 4, Curfew: a familiar face

Where	Who is there
Grand Staircase	Filch
The Library	Peeves, the ghost
Hospital Wing	the matron, the prefect (drained)

Appears: the Painted Double on the Grand Staircase, copying Prefect Sinclair. Cornish Pixies in the Library. Both leave at the end of the block.

TIP

Open tonight with a round of the Painted Double party game (Double tab). Then make it real: the Double is walking the castle wearing the face of a girl who is lying grey in the Hospital Wing.

READ ALOUD

Halfway up the Grand Staircase, in the light of a single torch, Prefect Sinclair is walking towards you. She is smiling. She is wearing her prefect's badge. She waves. Her skin has a faint sheen, like varnish, and when she steps into the torchlight, she does not cast a shadow.

The Sinclair sees her	Let the Sinclair decide first. Their sister is in the Hospital Wing. This one is smiling.
They talk to it	It speaks in her voice, a little too smoothly. It knows things only she would know. It asks them to follow it downstairs.
The Quill or the Okafor looks at it	Quill: it is painted. Okafor: it is a curse wearing a person.
They attack it	It is a mimic: it springs, and it fights. It copies the last spell cast at it.
They follow it	Towards the dungeons. It tries to lead them to the cold dead end. If they follow too far, it springs on them there.
They run	It does not chase. It watches them go, still smiling.

They go to the Library instead	Pixies. Lots of pixies, throwing books. The librarian is going to be furious tomorrow.
They go to bed	The Quill dreams of a corridor full of empty frames. At the end of it, a covered painting. The cloth is a little lower than last time.

Where the players should be by the end of Day 4

This is where the Guidebook stops. By now, most tables have:

- Learned Lumos, Expelliarmus and Avifors, and brewed Pepperup and Wiggenweld.
- Met everyone. Liked Ashgrove. Disliked Grimsby.
- Solved The Torn Edge, maybe the Scrambled Portrait or a rune tablet or two, fought pixies, a boar and a mimic.
- Seen two victims, heard “Canvas”, seen the empty portraits and the paint.
- Heard the name Corvin Vale, or found the page.
- Started or finished Wake the Sleepers, Where is Bramble?, Stolen Ingredients and The Other Half.
- A list of suspects, and strong opinions.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

End Day 4 by asking the table: “Who do you think it is? Each of you, one name.” Write the answers down. On Day 5, Grimsby will be found over a third victim, and you want to know who that surprises.

PART 5

The castle, room by room

Every picture, every object, and what happens when someone touches it.

Each place below matches its picture on the TV. The objects listed are the ones your players can actually see, so when someone points at the screen and says "I open that", you will find it here. Things marked **(find)** give a small find the first time each day; things marked **(clue)** or **(quest)** matter to the story. Everything else is flavour, and flavour is half the fun.

TIP

If a player pokes something not on these lists, use the Common things table in Part 1. Nobody will ever know the difference.

Entrance Hall

READ ALOUD

Great oak doors, iron-studded, stand open to the grounds. Four giant hourglasses glitter against the far wall, red, yellow, blue and green, each full of jewels. A grand staircase sweeps up to the right, its red carpet worn pale in the middle by a thousand years of feet.

Filch is here most mornings. The ghost drifts through at breakfast. Door pins lead to the Courtyard, the Great Hall, the Kitchens, the Grand Staircase and the Dungeons.

The hourglasses	The jewels inside are the house points, live. Touch the glass and your own house's jewels shimmer. If a student taps another house's hourglass, three jewels leap upwards, then fall back. Nothing changes; it is just showing off.
The oak doors	Heavy enough that it takes two first-years to move one. Carved into the inside of the left door, at knee height: hundreds of initials, the oldest five hundred years old. Students carve theirs on their last day. They can find a Blackwood's, and a Marlowe's.
Under the staircase	A dark arch, steps going down, cold air: the way to the Dungeons. Behind the stair itself, a cupboard full of mops that Filch would very much like them not to open (find: a Dungbomb confiscated in 1974).
The candelabras	Iron, taller than a student, dripping wax. One of them has a candle that never burns down. It has been lit for eighty years.
The alcoves behind the hourglasses	Shallow arches with stained glass. In one, a stone bench with a loose seat (find).
The banners	House banners and a tapestry of a unicorn hunt that is missing its unicorn. The unicorn is in another tapestry upstairs, hiding.

The Great Hall

READ ALOUD

Four long tables run the length of the hall, set with gold plates and goblets. At the far end, on a raised dais, the staff table, with a carved chair at its centre. Above, thousands of candles float under a ceiling that is not a ceiling: it is the sky, right now, whatever the weather is outside.

Everyone is here at Lunch. Flitwick runs the Dueling Club here every Free time from Day 2.

The floating candles	They drift when people walk beneath them. A Wingardium Leviosa on one: it floats exactly where the student wants, and the others follow it like ducklings.
The enchanted ceiling	It shows the real sky. On the night of an attack (Days 2 and 3), a star near the horizon goes out and comes back.
Under the tables	Chewing gum from 1890, a lost shoe, and on Day 2 a Chocolate Frog somebody dropped (find).
The staff table	Each chair is carved with its owner's initials. Ashgrove's is brand new and smells of varnish. Sitting in the Headmaster's chair: −10 points if anyone sees, and a portrait somewhere gasps.
The gold plates	Food appears at mealtimes only. Out of mealtime, asking a plate politely for a sandwich gets a sandwich, once. Asking rudely gets a sprout.
The banners and pillars	House banners. Behind the Hufflepuff banner, someone has carved "P.S. loves R.T." in 1962.
The door behind the staff table	A small chamber where the staff meet. Locked. Through the keyhole: a painting of a sunlit garden, new this year, hung by Ashgrove.

Grand Staircase

READ ALOUD

Stairs on stairs on stairs, criss-crossing in the air, some of them moving. Every wall is covered floor to ceiling in gilded portraits, and every portrait is talking at once. Candles burn in iron brackets. Somewhere above, a staircase grinds slowly into a new position.

Peeves lives here. The ghost passes in the afternoons. Prefect Sinclair meets the players here on Days 1 and 2. At Curfew, Filch patrols. Twelve door pins lead almost everywhere in the castle.

The portraits	Every one has a personality. Roll a d6: 1 a knight who challenges them to a duel; 2 a lady who gossips (spin Portrait gossip); 3 a sleeping wizard who is pretending; 4 a painted dog that follows them from frame to frame; 5 a portrait that is empty (from Day 2, more of them); 6 a portrait that tells them something useful (a passage, a password, where Peeves hid the jars).
A moving staircase	Ride one: spin Hogwarts surprises. Jump between two moving staircases: DEX 12, a fall is 2 HP and a lot of laughter from the portraits.
The trick step	Halfway up the third flight, one step is not there. Anyone who does not know steps right through it and is stuck to the knee until someone pulls them out (STR 10).
Behind a portrait	Hidden passages are behind three of the portraits here (see Hidden passages in Part 1). One has spy holes into the Defence classroom.

The serpent on the banister	A small carved snake on the lowest banister. Only the Marlowe notices it hisses back when they speak Parseltongue: it says the staircase moves on Fridays.
The candles	Lumos is not needed here. Ever.
Peeves's landing	Day 1 Free time: the stolen ingredient jars are up here (quest). Reaching them: Wingardium Leviosa, a moving staircase, or making Peeves fetch them.

The Kitchens

READ ALOUD

Behind a painting of a bowl of fruit, a vast warm room exactly the size of the Great Hall above. Three huge fireplaces roar: a boar turning on a spit, a cauldron of stew, bread rising on the hearth. Copper pans hang from the ceiling on chains. Everywhere, small figures in tea towels are running.

Pip and the house-elves, always. Day 1: a Small chest by the ovens. Door pins lead to the Entrance Hall and to the Hufflepuff common room (the barrels).

The fruit painting (the way in)	Tickle the pear. It giggles and turns into a door handle. Tickling the apple instead makes it bite.
The fireplaces	Hot. A student who leans in gets soot on their face and a slice of roast. Behind the third fireplace, at the back: a tiny elf-sized door that leads nowhere they can fit.
The hanging pans	Bang one and every elf stops and looks up. Then they all offer food at once.
The bread and vegetables	Help yourself and Pip is thrilled (find: a Pumpkin Pasty, every visit).
The barrels in the corner	They are the barrels of the Hufflepuff entrance, from the other side. A Hufflepuff can show the others the rhythm.
The sacks	Flour. Someone tips one and the elves are in fits of laughter for ten minutes.
Asking the elves for help	Pip will carry a message, fetch a snack, or tell a rumour (Part 2). An elf will never betray a student. Or a teacher.

The Dungeons

READ ALOUD

Cold stone and green light. Shelves of jars climb every wall: roots, eyes, things floating in murky liquid that turn to watch you. Desks are set with cauldrons over small blue flames. At the back, under a carved stone mantel, a fireplace burns low, and a cauldron bubbles on its own.

Grimsby is here all day. Door pins lead to the Entrance Hall, the Slytherin common room and (once found) the Undercroft.

The ingredient jars	Most are labelled in Grimsby's spiky hand. Boomslang skin: nearly empty. Lacewing flies: empty (clue, Day 1). Taking any: −10 points if Grimsby is in the room. A pinch of something useful is a find.
The store cupboard	Day 1 Free time onwards: lock forced, a smear of something sticky and slightly see-through on the handle (Peeves, quest).
The cauldrons on the desks	Leftover potions from class. Taste one: spin Potion brewing for what it does.

The fireplace at the back	Warm, carved with snakes. A Hard WIS search (15), or the Marlowe listening: behind the fire, the stones are cold. A narrow stair goes down. This is the way to the Undercroft (see When they go somewhere early, Part 1).
The scales and mortars	Brass scales that weigh true. A mortar with something still in it: crushed beetle, smells of cinnamon.
The green lanterns	They burn without oil. A Finite on one: it goes out, and every jar in the room goes dark for a heartbeat.
Grimsby's office door	Locked. Behind it (Day 5): the Restorative Draught. Before Day 5: very bad poetry and a cat-shaped tea cosy.

The Library

READ ALOUD

Silence so deep you can hear dust settle. Shelves rise two storeys high, with a gallery running round the top and rolling ladders on brass rails. Reading desks glow with green-shaded lamps. A worn blue rug runs down the middle aisle to an arch at the far end, and above it a dark door on the gallery stays shut.

The librarian, always. Wren Ashby in Free time from Day 2. Day 1: a Locked chest and the first rune tablet. Day 3 Lunch: the second victim. Door pins lead to the Grand Staircase and (once found) the Restricted Section.

Searching the shelves	INT 12 for any topic. Paintings: "Portraiture, aisle nine" and a note that the good book is in the Restricted Section. Runes: a children's primer with three runes in it (confirm three letters in the rune notebook). Hogwarts history: the castle was painted by Corvin Vale three hundred years ago, one line in a footnote (clue, Day 3+).
The ladders	They roll. Ride one down the whole aisle: DEX 10 to stop at the end. Fail: they crash into a shelf and twelve books fall, and the librarian appears instantly.
The gallery	The door at the top leads to the Restricted Section (see below). The gallery shelves have the old, heavy books. One sighs when opened.
The reading desks	Ink, quills, a lamp that brightens when someone reads well. The first rune tablet is on one of them (Day 1).
The globe	Spin it and it shows tomorrow's weather. Stop it with a finger on Hogwarts and the tiny castle has one window lit, deep under the ground.
The windows	Moonlit, tall, with a seat. A note tucked in the seat cushion: someone's revision timetable, colour-coded, very sad (find).
Making noise	"SHHH." −5 points and disadvantage on the next search.

The Restricted Section

READ ALOUD

Behind a barred iron gate, chains hang from the shelves, and the books on them pull against the chains like dogs on leads. Velvet ropes on brass posts mark a path down the middle. A single lantern burns. At the far end, a tall window lets in moonlight and nothing else.

Secret until found. The way in is a chained gate at the back of the Library (or the door on the gallery). The lock ignores Alohomora: the librarian has the key. The ghost reads here at night. Day 3 Free time: the first diary page. Day 4: the page about Vale, until Free time.

The gate and padlock	Old magic: Alohomora fails with a puff of chalk. Hairpin and DEX 15, the Okafor's Curse-Breaker gift, a forged teacher's note, or a Penrose wearing the librarian's face.
The chained books	They whisper. Read one: WIS 12. Success: a useful line (a rune letter, a clue). Failure: the book bites (1 HP) or screams, and someone is coming.
Lives of the Lesser Masters	On a reading stand, open, a page torn out. On Day 4, the page itself is here (quest, clue): until Free time, then it is gone.
The velvet ropes	Step over them and the floor creaks loudly. Step under them and nothing happens. The library has opinions.
The chests on the floor	Locked, chained, humming. Not on the map: they are flavour. If someone insists, one has a book inside that is reading itself aloud.
The window	From here, the dead-end corridor below the castle is directly underneath. On cold nights, frost on the glass forms the shape of a frame.

Charms classroom

READ ALOUD

Tiered wooden desks climb towards the back, covered in scrolls and inkpots. Feathers drift through the air from someone's levitation practice. Tall windows pour in light. At the front, beside the blackboard, a stack of books taller than a first-year serves as the professor's podium.

Flitwick, always. Door pin: the Grand Staircase.

The book stack	Flitwick's podium. Pull one book from the middle: the whole stack sways. DEX 12 to catch it, or −5 points and an apology.
The floating feathers	Left over from Wingardium Leviosa. Catch one: it is a perfect quill and writes in silver ink (find).
The chests by the window	Confiscated items. Locked (Hard DEX): a Dungbomb, a love letter, a toy wand that turns into a rubber chicken.
The globes	One shows the stars. One shows the castle from above. One shows nothing but fog and is labelled "Do not use".
The blackboard	Today's lesson in Flitwick's neat, tiny handwriting. Someone has drawn a duck at the bottom.

Transfiguration classroom

READ ALOUD

Rows of heavy desks face a blackboard on a wooden stand. A candle chandelier hangs low. On the side tables, cages hold beetles, a bird, and something in a teacup. Tall windows look out over the lake. Everything is very neat.

Vance, always. Door pin: the Grand Staircase.

The tortoise in the teacup	Half tortoise, half teacup, very friendly. It was a student's homework in 1999. It likes being stroked under the chin.
The cages of beetles	Practice subjects. Open one: beetles everywhere, Vance is not amused (−5 points).
The blackboard	It corrects spelling by itself, in red chalk, while you write.
The drawers	Neatly labelled. One says "Failed transfigurations": a chair with paws, a cushion that breathes.
The windows	The lake below. The Black Lake jetty is just visible (the second diary page is there on Day 4).

Defence classroom

READ ALOUD

Paintings. Everywhere, paintings: on every wall, leaning against desks, stacked on the floor three deep. Landscapes, old wizards, a ship in a storm. A blackboard at the front, Ashgrove's desk beneath it, and a globe by the window. It should feel cosy. It feels watched.

Ashgrove, always. Door pin: the Grand Staircase. Every day there are a few more paintings than the day before (clue).

The paintings (counting them)	Day 2: twenty-three. Day 3: twenty-six. Day 4: twenty-nine. Nobody sees him hang them (clue: more paintings every day).
Looking a portrait in the eye	It looks back. Its eyes follow. With a WIS 12: they are all painted in the same hand, whatever their age.
Turning a painting round	The back of every frame is stamped with the same small mark: a paintbrush crossed with a serpent.
The ship in a storm	The waves move. On Day 4, if someone stares long enough, there is a figure on the deck looking out at them.
Ashgrove's desk	See his card in Part 2: marking, a wet paint rag, a sketch of the Undercroft corridor.
The stacked frames on the floor	Empty frames. Several. Where did the people in them go?
The Quill asks "what is enchanted?"	"All of them."

Trophy Room

READ ALOUD

Long glass cabinets of silver cups and shields stretch away into the dark, each one polished to a mirror. A runner of red carpet leads to a stained-glass window at the far end. Banners hang between the arches. Somewhere in the cabinets, something rattles.

Filch, every afternoon and evening (detentions happen here). Day 1: the first ring clue, behind a cup. Day 3 Curfew: the Hungry Trunk, disguised as a Locked chest.

The cabinets	Cups for Quidditch, for duelling, for "Special Services to the School". Names the players might recognise from family stories.
The old cup	Engraved under the names of a forgotten team: a riddle (see The Old Cup, in the Quest Guide). Found during detention, or by a very good search.
Behind a cup	The Scratched note, the first ring clue (quest). WIS 12 notices it before Filch does.
The rattling cabinet	A cup that rattles because there is a tiny trapped pixie in it. Let it out and it steals something and flies away cackling.
The chest (Day 3 onwards)	It is the Hungry Trunk. The players cannot tell. Let them open it.
Polishing a cup	If they do it without being asked, Filch is so suspicious he follows them around for the rest of the block.

The Owlery

READ ALOUD

A round stone tower, freezing, open to the wind on every side through tall arched windows. Snow blows in. Hundreds of owls sit on perches and shelves, ruffled and blinking, and the floor is thick with straw and feathers. A spiral stair winds up the middle.

Nobody, apart from owls. Day 1: the third ring clue (Feathered card) and a Small chest.

The owls	Any owl will take a letter anywhere. One very old owl refuses to take anything and just stares at the Quill.
The windows	A sheer drop. Leaning out: DEX 10 or they drop whatever they are holding. The view is the whole grounds.
The straw	Search it and find owl pellets (gross) and, once, the Feathered card (quest).
The spiral stair	Goes up to a perch where the school owls sleep. Hooch says it is a minute to the Astronomy Tower by broom from here.
Flipendo in here	Owls everywhere. Feathers for an hour. Every owl in the tower refuses that student's post for a day.

The Astronomy Tower

READ ALOUD

The highest point in the castle. Brass telescopes stand on tripods along the stone parapet, pointing at a sky full of stars. A spiral stair comes up through the floor. Against the wall, a desk is covered in star charts, a globe beside it, and banners embroidered with moons hang still in the windless cold.

Nobody, except at night. Day 1: the second ring clue (Star chart) and a Locked chest. The Serpent in the Stars puzzle is played here.

The telescopes	Look through one: the stars, close enough to touch. Look down through one: the Forbidden Forest, and something moving between the trees.
The desk of star charts	The Star chart ring clue is among them (quest). The others are homework.
The globe	A celestial globe. Spin it and the constellations glow, and one of them is a serpent.
The parapet	Lean over: the grounds, the lake, the hut, the Forest. A very long way down. Nobody should climb it, so someone will. DEX 12, or the Hufflepuff's Steadfast gets its first outing.
At night	Put the Serpent in the Stars on the TV if they look for it (after The Old Cup, or if they ask about the serpent).

Hospital Wing

READ ALOUD

Long rows of white beds behind folding screens. Tall windows, a dark rug, the smell of clean linen and something sharp. On two of the beds, from Day 3, students lie grey and still, as if painted in ash.

The matron, always. Prefect Sinclair from Day 3. Longbottom from Day 3 Lunch. Cassius on Day 3 Curfew.

The drained students	Eyes open. Wands crumbled to charcoal. Oil paint on their fingers. Holding the prefect's hand: "Canvas."
The bedside cabinets	Potions for the patients. Taking one: the matron sees everything (−10 points). Asking for one when hurt: she gives it, with a lecture.
The locked cabinet at the end	The old school Healer's cabinet. Nobody has the key. (A Hale's family letter mentions it. Behind it, you could put the casebook page: "alive but empty, as if someone had painted over her".)
The screens	Behind one screen, Cassius on Day 3 night, snoring with a Bludger bruise.
Getting healed	The matron heals any student to full, once per block.

Room of Requirement

READ ALOUD

A cathedral of forgotten things. Furniture piled to the ceiling, suits of armour, stuffed gargoyles, chests and trunks and broken mirrors, candles burning in odd places. In one corner a tall wardrobe stands open, and inside it the air glows and sparkles like a doorway to somewhere else.

Secret until found: walk past the blank wall on the seventh floor three times, thinking of what you need. It works any day. Day 1: an Ancient chest is here. The Turning Lock chest ticks in the corner.

Searching the junk	Everything here was hidden by someone. Every search finds something: a find, a lost homework, a crown far too small for anyone, a book of spells with one page that works.
The gargoyles	Stone. Unless someone says something rude, in which case one of them sneezes.
The glowing wardrobe	Step in: it is a wardrobe. Step out: they are somewhere else in the room. It is a joke the room is playing.
The ticking chest	A small iron chest with three stone rings. The Turning Lock. Before they have the ring clues, it will not open.
Asking for something specific	The room tries. A place to hide: perfect. A weapon: a pile of very old swords that are too heavy. The answer to the mystery: a mirror, showing them.

The Undercroft (if they find it early)

READ ALOUD

Below the dungeons, a long cold corridor of pillars, black with water. At its end, a great round door is carved with a stone serpent, coiled on itself. The air hums. On the walls, nothing. Then, at the end of a side passage, something large and wrapped in grey cloth, hanging alone.

Do not run the finale early. Before Day 7, this is atmosphere: the covered painting hangs here from Day 1 Curfew, the serpent door opens only for the Marlowe's key and Parseltongue, and the inner chamber beyond is sealed.

The serpent door	Stone, cold, carved with a snake eating its tail. It does not open to anything but the Marlowe's key and a word in Parseltongue. Behind it, a short passage, and a second door that hums and will not open until the seventh night.
The covered painting	See Part 1. It breathes. It says "Not yet, child."
The puddles	Black water. In one, the reflection of the painting is uncovered. Only in the reflection.
The chains on the floor	Old, rusted, broken. Something was chained here once. The breaks are fresh.
Staying too long	Every minute here, roll WIS. Failure: Fear for the scene, and a dream of paint that night.

Gryffindor common room

READ ALOUD

A round tower room in scarlet and gold. A fire roars under a stone mantel, squashy red armchairs drawn up to it. Lion tapestries on the walls. In the corner, the back of the portrait hole: a tall oval painting of a lady in pink, seen from behind.

House only. Door pin: the Grand Staircase (through the portrait).

The fire	Warm. A student who sits by it for a whole block heals 2 HP extra (on top of the morning rest).
The armchairs	Down the back of one: a Sickle and a Chocolate Frog card (find).
The chess tables	Wizard chess, the pieces shouting advice. Playing a game is a good way to practise for the Living Chessboard (and earns +5 points if they beat a prefect).
The desk	Someone's abandoned homework: an essay on the history of the castle, mentioning a painter called Vale (clue, if they need a nudge).
The trunks	Other students' belongings. Opening one: −5 points and a very awkward conversation.

Ravenclaw common room

READ ALOUD

An airy round room under a domed ceiling painted with stars, where tiny brass telescopes and planets turn by themselves. Blue curtains, tall windows, bookshelves between them. A round table covered in star charts. The door is oak, with a bronze eagle knocker that asks riddles.

House only. Prefect Sinclair is drained just outside on Day 2 Curfew. Door pin: the Grand Staircase.

The eagle knocker	A new riddle every time. If they answer well, it compliments them. If they answer badly, it sighs.
The domed ceiling	The stars move with the real sky. The serpent constellation is there if anyone looks for it.
The star charts on the table	Ravenclaw homework. One chart has the Astronomy Tower stars numbered, in a first-year's handwriting (a hint for the Serpent in the Stars).
The bookshelves	Ravenclaws lend books freely. A book on runes here confirms two letters.
The armchairs	Blue velvet, very comfortable. Someone has left a Focus Draught down the side of one (find).

Hufflepuff common room

READ ALOUD

A round, low, warm room, honey-coloured wood and copper and hanging plants everywhere. A fire crackles in a stone hearth beside yellow armchairs. Round doors lead off to the dormitories like the doors of burrows. The badger is on every banner.

House only. Door pin: through the barrels to the Kitchens.

The plants	They are healthy and slightly too friendly. One holds hands with whoever sits nearest.
The round doors	Dormitories. Very cosy. Everyone else is jealous.
The chest by the wall	House snacks. Help yourself (find: Pumpkin Pasty).
The copper pans	Polished. Bang one and the whole house comes out to see who is visiting.
The barrels (outside)	The entrance. Tapping the wrong one sprays vinegar.

Slytherin common room

READ ALOUD

A long, low room under the lake. Round windows look out into green water where weeds sway and, now and then, something huge drifts past. Serpents are carved into every pillar. Green lanterns hang from chains. A fire burns at the far end beside leather sofas.

House only. Door pin: back into the Dungeons.

The lake windows	Look long enough and a giant eye looks back (the squid, being friendly). On Day 4 night, the water is very still and something else, flat and pale, drifts past: a picture frame.
The serpent carvings	The Marlowe can talk to them. They are carvings: they say nothing. Except one, by the door, which says “Hello” back very quietly and then pretends it did not.
The chest	Slytherin house funds. Locked. Opening it is a terrible idea that a Slytherin will absolutely try. −10 points if caught; +5 Galleons if not.
The desk with maps	Someone has been mapping the dungeons, badly. A cold spot behind the Potions fireplace is circled with a question mark (a hint toward the Undercroft stair).

The Courtyard

READ ALOUD

Stone arches on every side, ivy, autumn trees dropping red leaves into a fountain in the middle. Benches under the arcades. Students everywhere at break, gossiping.

Peeves and Cassius in Free time on many days. Door pins lead to the Entrance Hall, the Greenhouses, the Black Lake, the Quidditch Pitch, the old gamekeeper’s hut and the road to Hogsmeade.

The fountain	Coins on the bottom. Taking one: bad luck (disadvantage on the next roll). Throwing one in and wishing: the next roll has advantage.
The leaves	Kick a pile: a toad, a lost scarf, a Chocolate Frog wrapper with the card still inside (find).
The benches	Carved with initials. One bench is always warm.
Chatting with students	Spin Hogwarts surprises, or give them one rumour about the attacks (true or false: your choice).
The arches	Through one, a short cut to the Greenhouses. Through another, a view of the Forest, too close for comfort.

The Greenhouses

READ ALOUD

Glass and iron, warm and steaming, plants everywhere: hanging from the roof, crowding the benches, glowing faintly in the corners. Earmuffs hang on hooks by the door. In pots along the front, something is crying.

Longbottom in the mornings and classes. Day 2 Free time: the second rune tablet. Door pin: the Courtyard.

The Mandrakes	Pulling one up without earmuffs: everyone in the room CON 12 or Stunned for a round. Longbottom is not pleased.
The earmuffs	Fluffy, warm, and one pair has a name sewn in: a professor's, from when he was a first-year.
The glowing mushrooms	Eat one: glow in the dark for a block (genuinely useful: free Lumos).
The plant with tendrils	It grabs (DEX 10 or Stunned until someone helps). Longbottom calls it "Gerald".
The seed trays	Under one, the second rune tablet (Day 2 Free time onwards).
The watering can	It waters whatever it is pointed at, including students.

The Quidditch Pitch

READ ALOUD

A vast oval of grass ringed by tall towers striped in house colours. Three golden hoops at each end. Wind whips the banners. In one corner, a wooden broom shed.

Madam Hooch, all day. Flying lesson on Day 4. Door pin: the Courtyard.

The broom shed	Locked. School brooms inside, each with a name and a personality. Borrowing one without Hooch: −10 points and a lifelong enemy.
The hoops	Climb a tower and look through one: the whole valley.
The stands	Under the stands: lost gloves, a whistle, a Galleon (find).
The towers	Each house's tower has its colours. Going up the wrong one gets booed by imaginary crowds.

The Black Lake

READ ALOUD

Dark water stretching to the far shore, where the castle rises lit against the sky. A wooden jetty juts out from the rocks beside a boathouse. Reeds. Mist. And out on the water, slowly, something enormous breaks the surface and sinks again.

Nobody. Day 4 Free time: the second diary page on the jetty. Door pin: steps up to the Courtyard.

The tentacle	The giant squid. Friendly, in its way. Throw it bread and it waves. Throw a spell at it and it throws the student into the lake (CON 10 or Stunned, and soaked).
The jetty	Day 4: a diary page under a stone, the ink half-washed (quest).
Skimming stones	A natural 20 on DEX: the stone skips all the way to the far side, and a light comes on in the castle window directly opposite.
The boathouse	The boats from the first night. One is still damp, though nobody has used them since.
Glacius on the water	A sheet of ice, ten feet across. Walk on it and it starts to crack.

The old gamekeeper's hut

READ ALOUD

A stone hut with a giant-sized wooden door and a chimney trailing smoke. Pumpkins the size of armchairs fill a patch beside a wheelbarrow and a broken cart. Beyond the fence, the trees of the Forbidden Forest begin.

Scamander most days. Day 3 Free time: the third rune tablet. Door pins lead to the Courtyard and into the Forest.

The giant door	Knock: a deep echo. Nobody answers. It is unlocked. Inside: one enormous chair, an enormous kettle, and a dragon egg (painted, a decoy) in the fireplace.
The pumpkins	Huge. One has a face carved in it that winks.
The crossbow	Old, heavy, unloaded. Scamander takes it off them politely.
The cart and crates	Feed for creatures. The Thornbury knows exactly what each one is for. Taking some for Bramble: Creature treats.
The fence at the Forest edge	Beyond it, the trees. A torn strip of grey hippogriff feather on a nail (Day 3 onwards).

The Forbidden Forest

READ ALOUD

Huge black trees, roots like arms, mist lying on the ground. Lanterns hang from branches here and there, left by someone, still burning. Pale blue mushrooms glow at the foot of a stump. In the dark between the trees, eyes, many of them, catching the light.

Out of bounds. The centaur from Day 1 afternoon. Scamander on Day 3 Free time. Day 3: a Thornback Boar. Spin the Forest wheel on every visit.

The eyes in the dark	Owls, mostly. Some of them blink sideways. Ask the Thornbury what they are: “Better not to know.”
The lanterns	Who hung them? Nobody knows. They lead deeper in, towards Bramble.
The glowing mushrooms	Same as the greenhouse ones: eat one, glow for a block.
The path	It goes deeper. Every time they go deeper, spin the wheel again.
Bramble	From Day 3: deep in, afraid, a torn tag on her leg. See Where is Bramble? in the Quest Guide.

Prologue places

Place	Things to poke	What happens
Gringotts	The counters and scales; the mine cart tunnel; the chandeliers	Goblins weigh jewels and do not stop. The mine cart ride is the best thing in the world. Touching a goblin’s scale: he stares until they apologise.
Diagon Alley	Shop windows, barrels outside the apothecary, the owl cage, broomsticks	See Scene 3 in Part 3. Every window has something absurd for sale.
Ollivanders	Wand boxes, the rolling ladder, the chair, the papers on the desk	Boxes hum. Opening them makes wands misfire. The papers are receipts going back to 382 BC.
Platform 9¾	The barrier, the trolleys of trunks, the owl cages	Run at the barrier or bump your nose. An owl escapes from a cage and lands on the Thornbury.
The Express	Compartments, the trolley, the luggage car, the windows	See Scene 5. The luggage car is where the covered painting is.

Hogsmeade, the Three Broomsticks and the Shrieking Shack open on Day 6, after this book ends.

PART 6

The mystery so far

What is true, what the players can find, and what to do when they point a finger.

What is really going on

Keep this to yourself. Three hundred years ago, the painter Corvin Vale sealed himself inside his own unfinished self-portrait to escape death. To finish it, he needs the light of the young: each student he drains gives the portrait more colour. This summer, Professor Ashgrove found the painting and brought it to Hogwarts. Since then Vale has been in Ashgrove's head. By day Ashgrove is himself, mostly. By night Vale uses his hands: hanging new portraits as eyes around the castle, stepping out of frames to drain a student, slipping back. On the seventh night, the portrait will be finished and Vale will walk free.

Question	The truth
Who is draining the students?	The covered painting (Vale). Ashgrove is the hands.
Why the empty portraits?	Portraits are frightened of Vale. When he passes through a corridor, they flee their frames.
Why paint on the victims?	He touches them to take their light. Oil paint, crimson and gold.
Why Ashgrove's paintings?	Each new portrait is a window for Vale. He sees through them.
Is Grimsby guilty?	No. He is secretly brewing a draught to wake the victims. Peeves stole his ingredients.
Is Filch guilty?	No. He has keys everywhere, but he was in detention on night two.
Is Cassius guilty?	No. He was in the Hospital Wing on night three.
Is the ghost guilty?	No. She is a witness. Vale painted her once.

The suspect board

The TV shows tab has a suspect board with six suspects: Professor Ashgrove, Professor Grimsby, Argus Filch, Cassius Thorne, a Hogwarts ghost and the covered painting. When the players find a clue, pin it under the suspect it points at. The board is the players' detective wall: leave it on the TV while they argue.

ON THE GM SCREEN

TV shows tab: Suspect board. Pin each clue under a suspect as it is found. Mark a suspect Cleared when a clue clears them. Back to the map when they are done talking.

Every clue up to Day 4

Clue	Where and when	How they get it	Points at
Grimsby's store cupboard was raided	Dungeons, Day 1 Free time	Grimsby tells them; or they look at the cupboard	Grimsby (a red herring)
Filch has keys to every corridor	Anywhere Filch is, Day 1+	Filch boasts about his keys	Filch (a red herring)
Every portrait near an attack had gone silent	Ravenclaw Tower Day 2 Curfew; Library Day 3 Lunch	They look at the empty frames; Flitwick from Day 3	The painting
Ashgrove's classroom has more paintings every day	Defence classroom, Day 2+	They count the frames; Ashgrove shows them off; Longbottom (Day 6)	Ashgrove
Filch was supervising a detention on night two	Filch, Day 3+	They ask Filch where he was	Clears Filch
A ghost saw a figure "step out of a frame"	The ghost, Day 3+	They ask the ghost what she saw	The painting
The covered painting's eyes follow a Quill	The Express (Day 0), the Undercroft	Only the Quill sees it	The painting
The covered painting hangs in a different corridor each night	Filch or Peeves, Day 4+	Filch complains about paintings; Peeves rhymes	The painting
Cassius was seen with half of an old map	The Courtyard, Day 4 Lunch	They see him with it	Cassius (a red herring)
Cassius was in the Hospital Wing himself on night three	The matron, Day 4+ (or seen there Day 3 night)	They ask the matron	Clears Cassius
A page about Corvin Vale	Restricted Section, Day 4, until Free time	They pick it up	The painting

Things that are not on the board, but should make them think

- "Canvas": what Prefect Sinclair whispers if someone holds her hand (Day 3+).
- Oil paint on the victims' fingers, and a smear of crimson and gold on an empty frame.
- Ashgrove touching his cuff and lying about Vale (Day 4, WIS 12).
- The ghost knew Vale. The Headmaster's predecessor invited Vale to paint the staff.
- The Okafor's mother wrote "Occupied" on the painting. The Hale's great-grandmother saw this before. The Penrose's ancestor sat for a painter and lost her face.
- Longbottom: "All of them were near a painting. The night before, every one of them said they'd been dreaming about paint."
- Wren Ashby's secret (Card Collector): "Ashgrove signed for the new portraits himself."

The rule of three

Players miss clues. They forget them, misread them, or never open the right barrel. So every conclusion they need has at least three ways to reach it. If they miss one, the next will find them.

They need to realise…	Ways to get there
It has something to do with paintings	The empty portraits. The paint on the victims. Longbottom's dreams of paint. The ghost's figure stepping out of a frame. The Quill's eye.
There is something under the castle	The prefect's cold dead end. The humming. Pip's door that wants opening. Scamander's "something under the castle is calling". The centaur's "waking beneath the stone".

They need to realise...	Ways to get there
The name is Corvin Vale	The torn page (Day 4). The ghost (Day 4). The Headmaster (Day 4). The Library footnote (Part 5). The Three Broomsticks (Day 6, after this book).
Ashgrove is involved	The growing number of paintings. His lie about Vale. The sketch in his desk. Wren's secret. (Day 5: wet paint on his sleeve. Day 6: his eyes.)

TIP

If the table is completely stuck at the end of a day, give them a free clue through the world: a portrait whispers to them in the corridor, Pip brings a note with breakfast, or the Pocket Finds table rolls a 20. Never through a teacher telling them the answer.

When they accuse someone

They will. Usually Grimsby, often Filch, sometimes Cassius, occasionally each other. Every accusation is good: it means they care. Here is how to handle each one up to Day 4.

They accuse Grimsby	Perfect: he is built for it. Let him be rude, let him be suspicious, let them find the raided cupboard and the shaking hands. Do not clear him before Day 5. The Day 5 beat (Grimsby over the third victim) will feel like proof, and the truth (the draught) will feel like a twist.
They accuse Filch	He is clearable from Day 3: he was supervising a detention on night two. If they ask him, he tells them, outraged.
They accuse Cassius	Clearable from Day 4: the matron. Until then he sneers and refuses to deny it, because denying it would be beneath him.
They accuse Ashgrove early	Do not punish them, and do not confirm it. He is hurt and kind and gives them house points for courage. The other teachers are scandalised. Everyone else in the castle likes him. Make them doubt themselves.
They accuse the painting early	They are right, and that is fine. Nobody can do anything about it yet: it cannot be harmed, it is hidden below the castle, and nobody believes first-years about a painting. The question becomes how, and who is helping it. That is plenty of mystery.
They accuse each other	Lovely. The Painted Double night (Day 4) is built for this. Let them argue.
They want to tell a teacher	The teachers listen. Vance asks the hard question. The Headmaster says "Thank you" and looks frightened. Ashgrove says "Leave it to us." Nothing changes. Adults are slow.

ON THE GM SCREEN

For a mid-week vote, TV shows tab: Call an accusation vote. When the votes are in, Show the votes, then Keep it a hunch: their pick is stamped Accused and nothing is revealed. Save the final accusation for Day 7.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

At the end of every day, ask: "Who do you think it is, and why?" One sentence each. It costs you thirty seconds, and it tells you exactly which clue they are missing.

PART 7

The Quest Guide

How to get a table to bite, and every quest in depth.

A quest is just a reason to go somewhere and do something. Your players are curious and they will chase anything that looks interesting, but they will also chase things you never planned and ignore the quest you carefully set up. This guide is about steering without pushing: making the quest look more interesting than whatever else they were going to do.

How quests work in the app

- Each quest is **on offer** for a few blocks, from the person who gives it. During that window, the person has a scroll above their head on the TV.
- Give a quest from the Quests tab (tick who it is for) or straight from a conversation. It appears on their phones with its objectives.
- If nobody picks it up before the window ends, the quest giver **sends it by owl** at the start of the next block. Nothing important is ever lost.
- Tick objectives as they happen. Complete pays the rewards and plays the quest scroll on the TV and every hero's phone.
- Secret quests stay hidden until you reveal them, because they are found by curiosity, not handed out.

Twelve ways to make them bite

Technique	How	Example
Make it personal	Tie the quest to a player's family, secret or backstory.	Bramble is the Thornbury's hippogriff. The other half of the map belongs with the Fenwick. Never say "a quest": say "your hippogriff".
Put a face on it	The person asking must care, visibly.	Longbottom's hands shake holding the Mandrake leaf. The prefect pretends she is not frightened. Play the feeling, not the task.
Show, don't tell	Let them see the problem before anyone explains it.	They walk past the raided cupboard before Grimsby storms out. They find the empty frames before anyone mentions portraits.
A ticking clock	Say when the chance ends.	"Scamander says the hippogriff won't stay at the forest edge past tomorrow." The app marks Last chance on the final block.
Put the reward on the table	Say what they get, early and concretely.	"Grimsby gives anyone who finds the jars ten Galleons and two Pepperup Potions." Players love a price tag.
A rival wants it too	Competition makes anything valuable.	Cassius wants the Dueling Club title. Cassius has the other half of the map. Peeves is going to throw the jars at someone.
Curiosity over obligation	A locked thing, a riddle, a noise. Nobody can resist.	The ticking chest in the Room of Requirement. The riddle on the old cup. A rune tablet nobody can read.
Let them overhear it	Information they were not supposed to get is always more exciting.	Extendable Ears outside Grimsby's office. Pip gossiping with another elf. Two portraits arguing.
Small yes, then big yes	Ask for something tiny first.	"Could you just carry this note to the Hospital Wing?" Now they are in the Hospital Wing, and Longbottom is there.
Give each player a thread	When the party splits, each group should have something to chase.	Thornbury to the forest, Fenwick to the courtyard, the rest to the library. Cut between them on cliffhangers.

Technique	How	Example
Reward the weird solution	If their plan is clever and not on the list, let it work.	Bribing Peeves with a Dungbomb to fetch the jars. A Penrose wearing Filch's face. Let it work, and give house points.
Let ignored quests change the world	Do not force. Show what happened because they didn't.	Nobody found the jars: Peeves throws them in the Great Hall, and Grimsby blames the first-years. Nobody went to Bramble: she is gone deeper, and harder to find.

When they ignore a quest

Climb this ladder one rung at a time. Most quests are picked up by rung two.

Rung	What you do
1. Ask again, differently	The quest giver finds them at the next meal with a new angle: more personal, more urgent, or a better reward.
2. The owl	The app sends the quest by owl when the window closes. The letter is written in the giver's voice. It lands at breakfast in front of everyone.
3. The world moves	Something happens because they waited: another victim, a rival takes the prize, a clue is lost.
4. Let it go	Some quests are just not for this table. Drop it, and if it mattered, find the important part another way (see the rule of three in Part 6).

When they break a quest

They will solve things the wrong way, skip steps, kill the thing you needed alive, or lose the item. Never let a quest end in "you can't do that". Fail forward: the quest continues, but differently.

They skip a step	Tick it anyway. If the step mattered, its information arrives another way.
They lose a quest item	Someone finds it and returns it, for a price: Peeves wants a favour, Filch wants an apology, a portrait wants a secret.
They hurt the quest giver's feelings	The giver still needs the job done. They send the reward through someone else, coldly, and the relationship has changed. That is a story too.
They finish it in five minutes	Good. Reward them, and add one complication from the quest's list below to the next quest instead.

The quest calendar

Quest	Giver	On offer	Then by owl
Keep an Eye Out	Prefect Sinclair	Day 1 Lunch to Day 2 Free time	Yes
Stolen Ingredients	Grimsby	Day 1 Free time to Day 3 Free time	Yes
Card Collector	Wren Ashby	Day 2 Lunch to Day 5 Free time	Yes
Dueling Club Champion	Flitwick	Day 2 Free time to Day 4 Lunch	Yes
The Hollow Heir (main)	Everyone	After the first victim: Day 2 Curfew to Day 3 Lunch	Yes, from the Headmaster
Wake the Sleepers	Longbottom	Day 3 Lunch to Day 5 Lunch	Yes
Where is Bramble?	Scamander	Day 3 Afternoon to Day 4 Free time	Yes
The Other Half	Cassius	Day 4 Lunch to Day 6 Lunch	Yes, to the Fenwick
The Old Cup (secret)	—	Any detention	No

Quest	Giver	On offer	Then by owl
The Turning Lock (secret)	—	Finding the Room of Requirement; Day 5 Free time to Day 6 Free time	Yes, from an unknown hand
The Painter's Bargain (secret)	The painting	Day 5 Curfew to Day 6 Curfew	Yes, to one student
The Trials Beneath (secret)	—	Reaching the serpent door: Day 7 Lunch to Curfew	No

PART 7

Every quest in depth

Pitches, plays, shortcuts and spanners.

The Hollow Heir

The main quest. Winning it wins the campaign.

Given by	Everyone, after the first victim. The Headmaster's owl if they somehow avoid it.
Objectives	Find out what is draining the students. Learn the painted man's name. Find the way into the Undercroft. Stop the ritual before the seventh night ends.
Reward	150 XP and 50 house points each.

Three ways to pitch it

- The Sinclair's sister is grey in a hospital bed. Nobody needs to ask.
- The Headmaster, privately: "I will not insult you by pretending it was an accident. If you know something, tell me. If you find something, tell me first."
- The portraits, all over the castle, whispering the players' names as they pass. Something has noticed them.

How it usually plays

Through Day 4 it is a slow burn: clues, suspects, wrong guesses. The first two objectives can tick by Day 4 if they are sharp. The rest belongs to Days 5 to 7.

Clever solutions to allow

- Asking every portrait in the castle, one by one (the Blackwood can do this for real).
- Following the paint smears on empty frames to work out where Vale has been.
- Watching Ashgrove's classroom through the spy hole behind the Grand Staircase portraits.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- A third student is drained earlier than planned, near wherever the party is not.
- A teacher forbids first-years from wandering after a new rule: corridors closed after Free time.
- Someone they trust is the Painted Double for a scene.

If they ignore it	It cannot be ignored. If they are not chasing it, the victims come to them: a drained student in their own common room.
The payoff	Every clue they find goes on the suspect board on the TV. By the end of Day 4 the board should be full of arrows. That wall is the reward.

Keep an Eye Out

The prefect's worry. Makes her drained on Day 2 hurt.

Given by	Prefect Sinclair, Day 1 Lunch, to the Sinclair and anyone with them.
Objectives	Meet her after dinner. Follow her patrol. Find what she is afraid of.
Reward	30 XP and 10 house points.

Three ways to pitch it

- To the Sinclair, as family: "Meet me after dinner. Don't tell Mum. Don't tell anyone."
- To the group, as a dare: "You lot look like you can keep a secret. Want to see something creepy?"
- By accident: they see her standing alone by an empty frame, wand lit, looking frightened. She notices them noticing.

How it usually plays

They meet her at the Grand Staircase on Day 1 Curfew (or Day 2), she shows them the corridor of empty frames and the cold dead end near the dungeons. The third step (what she was afraid of) completes when they first see or feel the covered painting.

Clever solutions to allow

- Bringing her a gift (a Chocolate Frog) to make her feel better. +5 points.
- The Okafor touching the wall at the dead end.
- The Quill telling her about the eye on the train: she goes white and says "Me too. In my dreams."

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Filch nearly catches them on the patrol (spin Out after curfew; she covers for them).
- The Cornish Pixies on the Grand Staircase interrupt the meeting.

If they ignore it	She sends the owl on Day 2. If they still do not go, she is drained that night anyway, and the Sinclair finds the owl unopened in their bag. Ouch.
The payoff	On Day 2 Curfew, when she is grey on the floor, the players who walked with her should feel it. That is what this quest is for.

Stolen Ingredients

A comedy with a secret: it plants Grimsby as a suspect and gives the first hint he is decent.

Given by	Grimsby, Day 1 Free time.
Objectives	Search the Dungeons for clues. Catch the thief. Return the jars.
Reward	30 XP, 10 Galleons and two Pepperup Potions each. Grimsby adds 5 points each, quietly.

Three ways to pitch it

- Grimsby, furious and accusing: “If it was a first-year…” They want to prove it wasn’t them.
- A student whispers that Grimsby will give detention to all first-years if nobody confesses.
- They find a jar of lacewing flies on the Grand Staircase first, and Grimsby offers a reward for the rest.

How it usually plays

They find sticky, see-through fingerprints in the cupboard, follow a trail of lacewing wings to the Grand Staircase, and find Peeves juggling the jars on a high landing. Getting them back is the fun part.

Clever solutions to allow

- Bribing Peeves (he loves Dungbombs, and being called frightening).
- Wingardium Leviosa on the jars, or Accio once they have seen them.
- Getting Filch to chase Peeves away (Filch is thrilled to have a reason).
- The Penrose wearing Filch’s face.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Peeves throws a jar: lacewing flies everywhere, and everyone in the corridor sneezes for a block.
- One jar is missing: Peeves gave it to a portrait for safekeeping.
- Grimsby accuses a player of stealing them before they can return them.

If they ignore it	Peeves throws the jars across the Great Hall at Lunch on Day 3. Grimsby blames the first-years: −5 points to every house that has a first-year at the table.
The payoff	Grimsby’s “Five points. Each. Don’t tell anyone.” is the first crack in his armour. When he is found over a victim on Day 5, the players who did this quest will hesitate. Good.

Dueling Club Champion

Pure fun, and the best training for the reaction duel in the finale.

Given by	Flitwick, Day 2 Free time.
Objectives	Beat a rival. Beat two more. Win the final against Cassius.
Reward	40 XP and 15 house points each.

Three ways to pitch it

- Flitwick, bouncing on his books: “A first-year champion! Think of the glory!”
- Cassius, sneering: “First-years in the Dueling Club. That’ll be quick.”
- The whole castle is talking about it. The winner gets their name on a plaque in the Trophy Room.

How it usually plays

The Dueling Club runs every Free time in the Great Hall from Day 2. Place a Dueling Club rival and fight. Turn on the reaction duel on the rival's token so it feels like a real duel. The final is Cassius with rival stats.

Clever solutions to allow

- Fighting as a tag team (Flitwick allows it: "Two against one, how exciting!").
- Psyching the opponent out first: a good CHA roll gives advantage on the first spell.
- Studying the opponents during other duels (WIS: learn their favourite spell).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Cassius cheats: a hidden Jinx on the floor (Quill or Okafor can spot it).
- The crowd chants for the opponent. Disadvantage on the first roll unless someone wins them over.

If they ignore it	Nothing bad happens; they just miss out. Cassius wins and is insufferable about it until Day 7.
The payoff	House points, glory, and players who know exactly how the reaction duel works when the boss uses it for real.

Card Collector

A side trade that pays out a key clue.

Given by	Wren Ashby, from Day 2 Lunch.
Objectives	Find a rare Chocolate Frog card. Trade it to her.
Reward	25 XP and Felix Felicis. And her secret: the painting "came with the new portraits. Ashgrove signed for it himself."

Three ways to pitch it

- She offers a secret about the painting. Mystery players cannot resist that.
- She offers Felix Felicis. Gamers cannot resist that.
- She trades common cards for sweets, so they meet her through the Chocolate Frogs they open.

How it usually plays

The rare card comes from a lucky Chocolate Frog, an Ancient chest, or completing The Other Half. Bringing it to the Library ends the quest.

Clever solutions to allow

- Trading her something else rare (a hippogriff feather, a Gringotts goblin's signature).
- A convincing fake card (INT 14; she checks the back, so it needs to be very good).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Cassius wants the same card.
- She will only trade if they tell her a secret first.

If they ignore it	She sends an owl. If they never trade, they never hear her secret, and the Ashgrove clue must come another way.
The payoff	The secret is the first time anyone ties Ashgrove directly to the portraits. Deliver it slowly.

Wake the Sleepers

The emotional heart of the first half. Brings the prefect back with one vital line.

Given by	Longbottom, Day 3 Lunch, after the second victim.
Objectives	Gather 3 Mandrake leaves. Brew the Restorative Draught. Bring it to the Hospital Wing.
Reward	60 XP, 20 house points and a Wiggenweld Potion each.

Three ways to pitch it

- Longbottom, quietly, holding a leaf: “There’s a draught. It might bring them back.”
- The Sinclair, at their sister’s bedside, being told that there is a chance.
- The matron: “If Professor Longbottom’s draught works, perhaps. Until then, keep your voices down.”

How it usually plays

One leaf comes from each Herbology pass (Day 2). More from chests, from the Greenhouses with a sneaky search, or from Longbottom if asked well. Brewing: an INT check or spin Potion brewing. Grimsby can help (he is brewing the same thing, in secret, and it brings him into the story).

Clever solutions to allow

- Asking Grimsby to help brew. He refuses, then helps. It clears him early, if you want that.
- Stealing a leaf from the Greenhouses at night (DEX 12; the Mandrakes scream if they fail).
- Using the Hale’s Healer’s Hands to judge exactly when the draught is ready (advantage on the brewing roll).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- The cauldron explodes (spin Potion brewing), and they need one more leaf.
- Peeves steals the finished draught on the way to the Hospital Wing.
- It only wakes one student. Who do they choose?

If they ignore it	Longbottom brews it alone and it takes until Day 6. The prefect wakes too late to help much.
The payoff	The prefect wakes, grey slowly washing out of her face, and whispers: “The man in the painting… he was wearing Ashgrove’s face.” That line changes the game. Give it full weight.

Where is Bramble?

The Thornbury's quest. A trip into the Forest with a heart.

Given by	Scamander, after Care of Magical Creatures on Day 3. For the Thornbury.
Objectives	Find Bramble's tracks in the Forest. Calm her without hurting her. Bring her out safely.
Reward	50 XP, 15 Galleons and Creature treats each. Bramble can return in the finale.

Three ways to pitch it

- To the Thornbury: "I believe she might be yours."
- A grey feather on the fence by the hut, a torn tag tangled in it. The Thornbury recognises the crest.
- At night, from the common room window: a hippogriff's cry from the Forest. Only the Thornbury knows that call.

How it usually plays

Into the Forest (out of bounds), spin the Forest wheel each step deeper. The centaur gives a warning. The Thornback Boar is around on Day 3. Bramble is deep in, frightened, and will lash out at anyone but the Thornbury. Creature treats and Beast Bond make it gentle.

Clever solutions to allow

- Bowing to Bramble (how you greet a hippogriff). Advantage on calming her.
- Asking the centaur the right way (respectfully, about the stars) for directions.
- The Thornbury going alone. Brave, and Bramble trusts them more.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- The boar finds them first.
- Bramble is injured: a Healer's Hands or a potion must come first.
- Filch is at the Forest edge when they come out with a hippogriff. That is a lot of points.

If they ignore it	She goes deeper. If they try after Day 4, the Forest wheel needs to land on Hippogriff to find her at all.
The payoff	Bramble home, safe in the paddock. In the finale she can swoop in and carry one student out of danger. The Thornbury will cry. So might you.

The Other Half

The Fenwick's quest. Leads to the most magical moment of the first half: the map waking up.

Given by	Cassius, Day 4 Lunch in the Courtyard. For the Fenwick.
Objectives	Find out who has the other half. Win it back. Join the halves.
Reward	50 XP and a rare Chocolate Frog card (which finishes Card Collector).

Three ways to pitch it

- Cassius waving it in the Courtyard: “Finders keepers.”
- His owl: “I know you have half of an old map, Fenwick. I have the other half. Courtyard, any lunchtime, if you’re brave.”
- The Fenwick’s half grows warm in their pocket whenever Cassius is near.

How it usually plays

Win it by trade, trick or duel. Cassius respects all three. When the halves join, give the Fenwick the other half with Give item: the whole castle shows when the map is open.

Clever solutions to allow

- Challenging him to a Dueling Club final for it (ties into Dueling Club Champion).
- Trading the rare card (but then Card Collector needs another).
- Stealing it while he is in the Hospital Wing on Day 3 night (DEX 15, sneaky, very satisfying).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- He tore off a corner to keep for himself. The map works, but one room is missing.
- He wants to come with them. Let him. He is useful, and annoying.

If they ignore it	He sells it to an older student on Day 6. Getting it back is harder and costs more.
The payoff	The first time the Fenwick speaks the words and the whole castle appears on the TV with everyone’s footsteps: make the table go quiet for it. Turn the lights down.

The secret quests

These are found, not given. Reveal each one when the players stumble into it, and make the stumbling feel like their own cleverness.

The Old Cup

A secret that turns detention into treasure.

Found by	Detention in the Trophy Room (any Out after curfew that lands on Filch, or any rule-breaking he catches).
Objectives	Read the engraving on the old cup. Follow it to the Astronomy Tower. Find what was hidden there.
Reward	30 XP, the Moon ring clue and Felix Felicis.

Three ways to pitch it

- Polishing the oldest cup, they notice tiny letters: “Where the stars are closest, the second ring waits.”
- Filch, muttering: “That one’s haunted, that cup. Every year someone sees writing on it.”
- The cup is warm. Nothing else in the room is.

How it usually plays

Read the riddle, climb the Astronomy Tower, find the Star chart among the star charts. A great lead-in to the Serpent in the Stars puzzle.

Clever solutions to allow

- Players who get themselves detention on purpose to find it. Reward the scheming.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Filch is watching them polish. Reading the cup without him noticing: DEX 12.

If they ignore it	It stays a cup.
The payoff	It turns a punishment into a discovery, and teaches the table that breaking rules in this castle can pay.

The Turning Lock

The ticking chest in the Room of Requirement. Inside: the Time-Turner.

Found by	Finding the Room of Requirement. From Day 5 an unknown hand sends directions by owl.
Objectives	Find the room. Find the three ring clues (Trophy Room, Astronomy Tower, Owlery). Turn the rings.
Reward	60 XP, and by hand: the Time-Turner (one use).

Three ways to pitch it

- A ticking sound in the room that gets louder as they approach.
- The ring clues they found on Day 1 suddenly make sense.
- The unknown hand's owl, which nobody can trace.

How it usually plays

If they found the ring clues early (Day 1), this can come together fast. The answer is Serpent, Moon, Owl.

Clever solutions to allow

- Working out the room exists from rumours before the owl arrives.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- The room gives them what they need, not what they want: the chest is in a different place every visit.

If they ignore it	The owl arrives on Day 5 anyway.
The payoff	The Time-Turner is the safety net for the whole campaign. Players who have it play braver.

The Painter's Bargain (Day 5 onwards) and The Trials Beneath (Day 7) are in the DM Guide. They belong to the second half of the week.